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PROUD MOMENT

Dadasaheb Phalke Award for Anant Nag

Veteran actor to receive India's highest cinema honour on September 22

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JHIRAM VALLEY CASE

All convicts get death penalty for 2013 attack

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DELHI DECLARATION

Currency conundrum

Boosting local currency trade in BRICS is not a simple choice for India

EDITORIAL » PAGE 8



EYEING A SWEEP

Shreyas' men look for a perfect finish

SPORT » PAGE 16

INSIDE



More remains recovered from rubble in Gaza

GENEVA

The recovery of hundreds of bodies from the rubble of buildings destroyed by Israeli strikes in Gaza during the war that began nearly three years ago has raised fresh concerns about possible war crimes, the UN human rights chief said on Tuesday. Volker Turk said the remains appeared to be that of entire families. » PAGE 14

U.S. Fed Reserve hikes key rate for 1st time in 3 years

WASHINGTON

The U.S. Federal Reserve raised its benchmark interest rate on Wednesday for the first time since 2023 in an effort to quell stubbornly-high inflation, a move that could spur a sharp response from the White House. The quarter-point increase lifts the Fed's key rate to about 3.9% and, over time, could result in higher borrowing costs. » PAGE 14

U.S.-based group booked by CBI for FCRA violation

NEW DELHI

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has registered a case against seven accused, including the U.S.-based The Timothy Initiative, in connection with alleged routing of foreign funds into India, including to regions affected by left-wing extremism, through foreign debit cards, in contravention of the FCRA. » PAGE 4

Modi 'decided to prostrate before Trump over UPI'

NEW DELHI

Mounting a sharp attack on the Narendra Modi government over the introduction of a charge on certain UPI transactions, Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi on Wednesday accused the Prime Minister of "prostrating" before U.S. President Donald Trump, and demanded immediate rollback of the decision. » PAGE 5

Jaishankar begins two-day Bhutan visit

NEW DELHI

External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar on Wednesday arrived in Bhutan's capital Thimphu for a two-day visit to discuss India's development assistance, while Nepal Finance Minister Swarnim Wagle will arrive in Delhi on Thursday for talks likely to discuss India's support for Nepal's reconstruction post-floods. » PAGE 4

Pak. corvette collides with Indian warship after 'unsafe approach'

India summons Pakistan envoy, lodges strong protest over 'unprofessional conduct'; PNS Hunain approached Indian ship at high speed and suffered damage in collision; no casualties reported; the Indian ship was on a routine surveillance mission

Saurabh Trivedi

NEW DELHI

A Pakistan Navy corvette collided with a frontline Indian Navy warship after approaching it at high speed and manoeuvring in an "unsafe and unprofessional" manner in the North Arabian Sea on Tuesday evening. The incident prompted India to summon Pakistan's Chargé d'Affaires and lodge a strong diplomatic protest.

Defence Ministry sources said the incident took place in international waters while the Indian warship was on a routine surveillance mission. PNS Hunain (F-273) approached the Indian vessel while attempting to intercept or follow it. The close-range manoeuvre caused the two vessels to graze each other. Sources said PNS Hunain sustained damage in the collision and returned to the harbour. The Indian naval vessel suffered minor damage and continued on its mission. No casualties



The incident comes amid continued deployment of Indian and Pakistani naval assets in the Arabian Sea. In 2011, PNS Babur and INS Godavari were involved in a similar incident. FILE PHOTO

or major damage were reported from the incident.

"The Chargé d'Affaires of the High Commission for the Islamic Republic of Pakistan in New Delhi was summoned to the Ministry of External Affairs today and a strong protest was lodged with him over the unacceptable and unprofessional conduct of Pakis-

tani naval units at sea that led to a collision with a unit of the Indian Navy," the External Affairs Ministry said.

"While the incident, which took place in international waters, did not cause any major damage, the conduct of the Pakistani naval ship was in direct contravention of Article 10 of the Agreement between

India and Pakistan on Advance Notice on Military Exercises, Manoeuvres and Troops Movements of April 1991," it said.

The Pakistani diplomat was advised to convey to the authorities in Pakistan the need for all military units to exercise due care and respect the provisions of relevant bilateral agree-

ments to prevent a recurrence of such incidents.

The Indian Chargé d'Affaires in Islamabad has been instructed to lodge a similar protest with Pakistan's Ministry of Foreign Affairs, the government said.

Pakistan's response

Later, Pakistan summoned the Chargé d'affaires of the Indian High Commission in Islamabad and lodged a strong protest over what it termed a "highly provocative and unacceptable" action by an Indian Navy vessel in Pakistan's EEZ.

PNS Hunain is a Yarmook-class offshore patrol vessel built by Damen Shipyards in Romania and commissioned into the Pakistan Navy in July 2024.

The latest incident comes amid the continued deployment of Indian and Pakistani naval assets in the Arabian Sea. The exact circumstances leading to the close manoeuvring and collision are likely to be examined by the two sides through relevant channels.

Broken land



Worrying pattern: A farmer ponders his options on his parched field in Shivamogga district of Karnataka. The State government recently declared 101 taluks, spread across 24 districts, as drought-hit. S.K. DINESH

No change to panel probing police action on CJP stir: SC

Krishnadas Rajagopal

NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court has expressed "disquiet" at petitioners' aspersions of 'conflict of interest' within its high-powered committee formed to probe into the police crackdown on Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) protests on July 20. Refusing to reconstitute the panel, a three-judge Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant criticised the petitioners for indulging in "conjecture and pre-conceived notions".

FULL REPORT ON » PAGE 4

24 Delhi seats now have fewer electors than 2025 turnout

The Hindu Data Team

CHENNAI

Amid concerns over high rate of deletions in Delhi during the ongoing special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, an analysis has revealed that 24 of the 70 Assembly constituencies (ACs) in the National Capital Territory have fewer voters than the number of people who voted in the 2025 Assembly election.

These 24 ACs together had 49.1 lakh voters when

Delhi went to the polls, of which 28.9 lakh (58.9%) voted.

However, they now have only 27.7 lakh voters, which is 1.23 lakh fewer than those who voted in 2025.

In the draft rolls now, there are only 1,00,386 electors, which is 14,575 fewer than the 1,14,961 who actually turned out to vote in 2025.

DATA POINT ON » PAGE 9

Saudi Arabia accuses Houthis of targeting Mecca

Agence France-Presse

RIYADH

Saudi Arabia accused Yemen's Houthis on Wednesday of launching a "cowardly" attack targeting Islam's holy city of Mecca, sparking outrage across the Muslim world.

The Houthis swiftly rejected the Saudi claim that it had shot down a drone heading towards Mecca as a "lie". New fighting between the Iran-backed Houthis and Yemen's Saudi-backed government has dragged in the kingdom, after the Houthis declared a maritime blockade on Saudi ships in the Red Sea.

Last week, the Houthis seized control of Yemen's Red Sea coast and the Bab el-Mandeb Strait, a vital artery for Saudi oil exports as the wider war chokes off the Strait of Hormuz shipping route.

'Cowardly attack'

Saudi Arabia's Foreign Ministry condemned the targeting of Mecca as a "cowardly terrorist attack" and reaffirmed the kingdom's right to "defend the security of the two holy mosques, the pilgrims, and the entire Saudi territory".

Houthi politburo member Hazem al-Assad, however, dismissed the accu-



People and pilgrims gather at the Grand Mosque Complex in Saudi Arabia's holy city of Mecca on Wednesday. AFP

sation as "a worn-out lie that has been used before and no longer fools anyone".

The Saudi-led coalition battling the Houthis vowed retaliation, saying "the se-

Houthi Militia," it said.

Houthi military spokesperson Yahya Saree said Saudi Arabia had launched more than 450 strikes on Yemen this week, and that in response, the group had targeted a Saudi air base in the south and a state oil company facility in the Red Sea port city of Yanbu.

The Organisation of Islamic Cooperation – a bloc of 57 Muslim countries – condemned the "heinous attacks", while Arab League chief Nabil Fahmy called it "a matter of extreme gravity".

SAUDI PLANES POUND YEMEN » PAGE 14

INBRIEF



Despite bad health, Maratha activist to continue march

Maratha reservation agitation leader Manoj Jarange-Patil on Wednesday asserted that he would continue his march towards Mumbai and reach Azad Maidan on September 18 at 10 a.m., while his health has deteriorated, forcing him to stay in Patoda, Beed district. “I will leave on Thursday from Beed at 1 p.m. However, I will declare the date for Maratha community members to come to Mumbai later as government has sent some draft. I will read and let you know accordingly,” Mr. Jarange Patil. This also means the original plan to halt in Ahilyanagar’s Shrigonda region and Pune’s Hadapsar would no longer take place.

CISE, IIT-K sign MoUs to boost cybersecurity, anti-drone tech

The Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) has signed two MoUs with the Indian Institute of Technology (IIT), Kanpur to strengthen its capabilities in cybersecurity and anti-drone technology to secure critical and strategic infrastructure. The agreements, signed on Tuesday provide for a six-week cybersecurity training programme through C3iHub, a cybersecurity technology innovation hub at IIT Kanpur, and the establishment and development of a centre of excellence in anti-drone technology at the paramilitary force’s regional training centre in Rajasthan’s Behror town.

Nakkeeran journalist held for defamatory video against YouTuber

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The Adambakkam police on Wednesday arrested a 58-year-old journalist, Damodharan Prakash, of *Nakkeeran*, on charges of posting a defamatory video on social media against a 38-year-old YouTuber. In a press release, the police stated that Mr. Prakash had posted a “derogatory and defamatory” video in January this year against an Adambakkam-based woman working for a YouTube channel. Based on the complaint filed by the woman, the Adambakkam police filed a case under various sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, the Information Technology Act and the Tamil Nadu Prohibition of Harassment of Women Act, said the police.

Allahabad HC frees man confined after conversion, relationship with Muslim woman, cites Articles 21, 25

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

The Allahabad High Court on Wednesday set at liberty a 31-year-old man, Ayush Malik, who had accused his father of illegally confining him after he converted to Islam and entered into a relationship with a Muslim woman, Chandni Qureshi. Based on Mr. Ayush’s submission that he had voluntarily embraced Islam in 2014 and accepted Ms. Qureshi as his partner, the court observed that the choice of a person with whom an adult wishes to establish a matrimonial relationship forms part of the right to life and personal liberty under Article 21 of the Constitution. It added that such choices cannot be curtailed merely because they are contrary to the wishes of family members.

Following Mr. Ayush’s conversion from Hinduism to Islam, the police in Shamli district registered a case under the Uttar Pradesh Prohibition of Unlawful Conversion of Religion Act, 2021 against Ms. Qureshi and her father. The two were subsequently arrested in connection with the case and spent months in jail before being granted bail by a Shamli court on July 24. **Capable of decisions** A single-judge Bench of Justice Sandeep Jain, which was hearing a *habeas corpus* petition, said it was apparent from Mr. Ayush’s statements that he had attained majority and was capable of taking decisions concerning his life. In his plea, Mohd. Sultan, claiming to be Mr. Ayush’s friend, alleged that his friend had voluntarily embraced Islam without

coercion, undue influence or inducement and subsequently decided to marry Ms. Qureshi. The plea also claimed Mr. Ayush’s father, Devraj Singh Malik, had opposed the relationship. During his interaction with the Bench on Wednesday, Mr. Ayush said he had been subjected to threats and confined illegally by his father since June 4. Mr. Devraj disputed the allegations and told the court that his son had been influenced by “certain individuals”. After hearing both sides, the court said nothing had been brought on record to persuade it to disbelieve Mr. Ayush’s statement. “Freedom of conscience and the right freely to profess, practise and propagate religion are guaranteed under Article 25 of the Constitution,” the court stated in its order.

Man shoots dead teacher in Bijnor for ‘encouraging love jihad’

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

A 40-year-old primary school teacher, Naushad, was shot dead outside his school in Bijnor on Tuesday by a man who later surrendered and told the police that he suspected the teacher of “encouraging love jihad”, an officer said on Wednesday, adding that Mr. Rath was arrested after he surrendered. ‘Love jihad’ is a term coined by right-wing outfits for inter-faith couples. Naushad was preparing to return home after classes ended at Saupuri Primary School when Mr. Rath opened fire at him. Police said they are probing the accused’s statement and other aspects of the case. Bijnor SP K.K. Bishnoi said the reason for the murder had “not yet been established”.

Maharashtra farmers hold protests, seek drought aid; doing everything possible, won’t let them suffer: CM

Snehal Mutha
MUMBAI

A pause in the monsoon has led to a drought-like situation in parts of Maharashtra’s Marathwada and Vidarbha regions. At least 83 talukas in 19 districts have recorded a rain break of more than 20 days, with some areas going without rain for over 40 days, according to the State Agriculture Department. On Wednesday, farmers demanded that the Maharashtra government officially declare a drought in the affected districts, provide compensation and implement relief measures. The government has ordered a ground-level assessment from October 5 to assess the extent of damage and provide relief to affected farmers. Farmers in Washim and Beed districts took to the roads on Wednesday. In



As many as 83 talukas in 19 districts have recorded rain breaks of more than 20 days, as per the State Agriculture Dept. FILE PHOTO

Washim, the symbolic protests were led by NCP (SP) leader Rohit Pawar. “Farmers have lost their crop and are facing heavy losses. Labourers are similarly affected,” he said. Mr. Pawar sought compensation of ₹50,000 per hectare to farmers’ families and ₹25,000 for the families of farm labourers. Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis said, “We will not let farmers suffer. We will help them with everything

we have. I have instructed the officials concerned to prepare a framework to help those affected.” **Criticism from Oppn.** The Opposition has criticised the government for “wasting time” on surveys. Senior Congress leader Vijay Wadetiwar said, “The kharif crop has fallen into crisis. Farmers are facing losses in soyabean, paddy and other crops due to deficient rain.”

Assam’s Lok Sabha bypoll could define contours of Opposition politics in the State

NEWS ANALYSIS

Abdus Salam

The line-up for the Nagaon parliamentary seat byelection on October 6 is complete with the All India United Democratic Front (AIUDF) nominating its chief, Badruddin Ajmal, as its candidate on Tuesday. His entry makes it a four-way contest, with former legislator Sibamoni Bora of the Congress, former bureaucrat Devasish Sharma of the BJP and academic Abdul Salam of Trinamool Congress also in the fray. Nagaon is the first major face-off between the principal combatants, BJP and Congress, since the former’s crushing sweep in the April Assembly election with 102 out of 126 seats for the National Democratic Alliance. The AIUDF’s last-

minute candidate switch from former student leader Rejaul Karim Sarkar to its founder is a bold gambit that could radically alter Opposition politics in a foreseeable future where the ruling party holds near-absolute sway. Even as the upper regions of Assam were still reeling from the impact of sudden floods in July, the State’s broader Opposition unity fractured on September 3 when the Congress formally severed ties with Akhil Gogoi’s Rajiv Dal. Wazid Ali Choudhury, Leader of the Opposition in the Assembly, said the decision by the Congress leadership followed repeated criticism of the party by its ally. “Akhil Gogoi has constantly been criticising the Congress party and its leaders. We got tired of the fact that he was in an alliance with us and

still criticising us,” he said. The erstwhile junior ally chose to train its guns on Lok Sabha MP and Assam Congress chief Gaurav Gogoi, questioning the scale of his engagement with the flood crisis. While he opted not to put up a candidate in Nagaon in the interest of “preventing the rise of communal forces”, the Rajiv Dal chief is eyeing a larger chunk of the Opposition space over the full term of the BJP government. The party won two seats in the April election, Mr. Akhil Gogoi defending his Sibsagar seat from 2021 and Mehboob Muktar winning Dhing LAC in Nagaon Lok Sabha constituency. It could have added a third to its kitty, but the Congress’s veto forced Rajiv Dal to drop Sherman Ali Ahmed as its candidate from Mandia; Mr. Ahmed



The Cong., led by party’s State unit chief Gaurav Gogoi (second from right), has broken ties with Akhil Gogoi’s (left) Rajiv Dal. FILE PHOTO

promptly walked over to the Trinamool Congress and secured the party its sole seat. **Rajiv Dal’s long game** With only one non-Muslim among the Congress’s 19 winning candidates, the Rajiv Dal’s long game is clear: expand at the expense of the principal Opposition party among the Assamese Hindu voters, a prospect even Chief Minis-

ter Himanta Biswa Sarma had predicted in February this year. The Muslim vote isn’t a settled question either. The Congress wrested back much of this electoral constituency from the AIUDF in the last Assembly election after refusing to renew its tie-up in 2021, but dismal performances across seats with a thin minority concentration leave it vulnerable to another

shift. Mr. Ajmal set the cat among the pigeons as early as August 16 when he claimed - correctly, in retrospect - that the Congress will not field a Muslim candidate in the bypoll. By fronting himself as a candidate, the AIUDF chief, currently an MLA from central Assam’s Binnakandi seat and a former three-time MP from western Assam’s Dhubri, is going all in to reclaim the party’s core constituency. The arithmetic aligns: Nagaon has four Muslim-majority Assembly segments, Dhing, Rupahihat, Lahorihat and Samaguri, and four others - Nagaon-Batadraba, Jagiroad, Morigaon and Raha; over 55% of the parliamentary constituency’s voters are minorities. The BJP and AIUDF, with their respective Nagaon picks, have boxed the Congress in from both

flanks. State BJP chief Dilip Saikia and the CM have acknowledged the odds in a ‘non-traditional’ seat. The BJP is betting on a non-Muslim consolidation for Mr. Devasish Sharma, the former Nagaon Deputy Commissioner whose transition from bureaucrat on September 3 to BJP politician five days later sparked Congress outrage. The strategy, the CM spelled out, is to maximise its advantage in the four non-minority-heavy segments and narrow deficits in the rest. Mr. Ajmal and Mr. Salam’s candidatures ensure that every Muslim vote would be equally fought for. A Congress victory could only come about if it manages to draw support across sections of voters - essentially making its old winning formula work. The party could not afford to alienate non-minority

voters with a Muslim pick, having won the Lok Sabha seat twice in succession even as it slipped elsewhere against the BJP. The Nagaon poll is thus Congress’s to lose. “Congress will secure victory once again in the Nagaon bypoll. Consider this as an announcement,” Mr. Gaurav Gogoi had said even before the party announced its choice. A win here would indeed signal a vital shift: a diverse electorate, bridging religious divides, voting the Congress candidate first past the post and giving the party a credible shot at taking on the BJP five years down the road. A failure would mean the fundamental factor underlying its Assembly election rout persists - an inability to appeal to the Assamese Hindu voters beyond a certain threshold.

CM
YK

CBI books Timothy Initiative, six others over fund routing

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI



He said it is a time for introspection, especially for those who play "politics on the corpse of tribal communities and those who provide intellectual and ideological support to terrorism".

During the trial, the agency informed the court that members of the banned Communist Party of India (Maoist) attacked a convoy of about 20 vehicles carrying Congress leaders. The attackers triggered a landmine blast that blocked the route of the vehicles participating in the *Parivartan Yatra*. This was followed by indiscriminate firing and grenade lobbing, resulting in 24

Network led by Shahzad Bhatti listed as terror group

Bhatti, who speaks Punjabi and has a significant social media presence with regular posts on Instagram and Facebook, has been operating out of the United Arab Emirates (UAE), the officials said. Over the last one and a half years, he is said to have "graduated" from organised crime to "terror-related activities".

Without mentioning the specific cases against the network, the MHA notification listed nine categories of crimes registered against the group under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), the Information Technology Act, the Explosives Substances Act, the UAPA, the Official Secrets Act, the Immigration and Foreigners Act, and the Delhi Prevention of Defacement of Property Act.

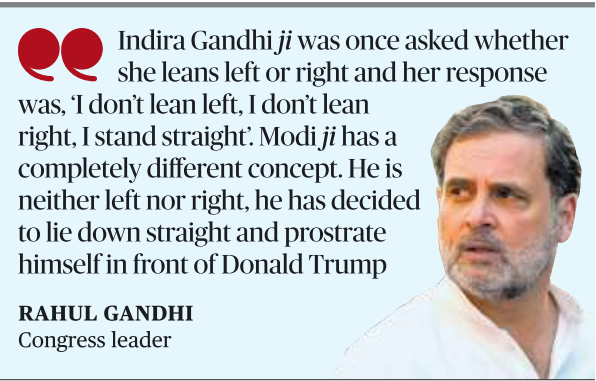
PM decided to prostrate before Trump, says Rahul on UPI fee

Modi govt. gave in to U.S. demand to get rid of zero MDR for UPI, says Jairam, questions if move intends to benefit U.S. card companies; Kharge terms U.S. threat of higher tariffs on countries buying oil from Russia a failure of India's foreign policy

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Mounting a sharp attack on the Narendra Modi government over the introduction of a charge on certain UPI transactions, Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi on Wednesday accused the Prime Minister of “prostrating” before U.S. President Donald Trump, and demanded an immediate rollback of the decision.

In a video posted on X, Mr. Gandhi said Mr. Modi had “decided to lie down straight and prostrate himself in front of Donald Trump”, and accused the government of imposing a “UPI tax” on Indians to give “a huge amount of money” to the United States.



“Indira Gandhiji was once asked whether she leans left or right and her response was, ‘I don’t lean left, I don’t lean right, I stand straight.’ Modiji has a completely different concept. He is neither left nor right, he has decided to lie down straight and prostrate himself in front of Donald Trump,” Mr. Gandhi said. “Modiji, stop lying down in front of the U.S.,



RAHUL GANDHI
Congress leader

have a spine, stand up and rollback the UPI tax,” Mr. Gandhi added.

The Congress has sought to link the UPI decision to what it describes as growing U.S. pressure on India, including demands for changes to the zero merchant discount rate (MDR) regime for UPI. The party has also stepped up its attack following moves in the U.S. Congress to im-

pose tariffs on countries buying oil and gas from Russia.

Congress general secretary in charge of communications Jairam Ramesh said the U.S. Trade Representative had earlier criticised UPI for being free and for having displaced card companies such as Visa and Mastercard.

“Here, the Modi government has given in to a U.S. demand to get rid of zero MDR and charge for UPI,” Mr. Ramesh said, questioning why the rate had been fixed at 0.4% and whether the move was intended to enable U.S. card companies to compete with UPI.

“The PM has redefined NOTA – Narendra’s Ongoing Trump Appeasement,” he said.

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge, reacting to the U.S. tariff legislation,

said the threat of higher tariffs showed that the government’s foreign and trade policies had “miserably failed”.

“From tariffs and trade to H1B1 immigration, visas and digital payments, the pressure from Washington keeps mounting, and you, ‘Howdy Modiji!’ keep surrendering!” Mr. Kharge said on X.

Earlier, Congress media and publicity department head Pawan Khara said: “We are not playing ball with America and China. We are the ball.”

The government, however, said the new MDR is not a charge on consumers.

Congress spokesperson Supriya Shrinete rejected the government’s position, saying the move would ultimately increase costs for ordinary users.

RSS affiliate urges govt. to look at ‘broader savings’ before imposing UPI fee

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

Ashwani Mahajan, co-convenor of the Swadeshi Jagran Manch (SJM), the economic wing of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), on Wednesday raised concern about the government’s proposed merchant discount rate (MDR) on UPI transactions above ₹2,000, calling for the move to be reconsidered. He argued that the fee was not justified by the costs involved.

In a post on X, Mr. Mahajan said there was little reason for banks to seek an MDR on UPI, pointing out that the digital payments system had helped bring down their costs in terms of ATMs and other infrastructure. “UPI transaction fee is most unfortunate. It’s demeaning an achievement of Bharat, which has global appeal. Policymak-



Centre has proposed a 0.4% MDR on merchant payments above ₹2,000 through UPI.

ers have failed to factor in reduced logistics costs due to UPI, making Bharat more competitive,” he said. He also argued that cybersecurity costs should not be cited as a reason for introducing the charge, saying such expenses were part of banks’ regular operations.

The government has proposed a 0.4% MDR on merchant payments above ₹2,000 through UPI. Payments between individuals

and smaller merchant transactions will not attract the fee.

“The question is, why them too?” Mr. Mahajan said, arguing that even bigger merchants shouldn’t be taxed for accepting UPI payments.

Speaking to *The Hindu*, Mr. Mahajan referred to concerns he had raised in a recent article about the United States Trade Representative and India’s zero-MDR system. The SJM co-convenor said the government should not change its policy because of such pressure. He said the growth of UPI had reduced the business of international card networks such as Visa and Mastercard and helped India save on foreign exchange outgo. “The government should look at the broader savings generated by UPI before going ahead with the proposed fee,” he added.

IPS officer transferred for using Arabic salutations

The Hindu Bureau
KOLKATA

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government in West Bengal has transferred IPS officer Bushara Bano, after right-wing groups raised objections against a video in which she is heard using using common Arabic salutations and greetings. Ms. Bano, who was posted as Additional SP of Kharagpur, has been transferred to the post of Deputy Commandant, SAP 4th Battalion.

In the video, in which Ms. Bano reflects on her personal journey, she is heard saying, “Assalamu Alaikum! I am a 2021-qualified IPS officer and currently deployed as Additional Superintendent of Police in Kharagpur...”

Mahua says she faced eggs like ‘freedom fighters faced bullets’

Shiv Sahay Singh
KOLKATA

Trinamool Congress MP Mahua Moitra on Wednesday alleged that BJP workers threw eggs at her during a visit to her Krishnanagar constituency in Nadia district of West Bengal.

In a series of posts on X, Ms. Moitra referred to an oral observation made by the Supreme Court last month, when it denied her permission to appear virtually before an investigating officer in a case over her allegedly provocative Facebook posts, on the apprehension that she might be attacked with eggs.

“Big shout out to Hon’ble Justice Dipankar Datta! MiLord - I came to my constituency for a mtng [meeting] informing @WBPPolice



Mahua Moitra

& BJP workers with their help pelted eggs on me. True to your advice I faced them as a freedom fighter faced bullets,” she posted.

During the August 7 hearing of Ms. Moitra’s plea, Justice Dipankar Datta had made the oral remarks that freedom fighters had faced bullets, when her counsel cited the possibility of eggs being thrown at her.

Oman pitches new port that could expand India’s access to Gulf energy

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

With the Strait of Hormuz in a chokehold due to Iran-U.S. hostilities, Oman has pitched investment opportunities to India in a new port that could provide uninterrupted access to energy resources from the Persian Gulf.

Speaking here on Wednesday, a high-level representative of the Sohar Port of Oman welcomed Indian investments into the port and said it would serve as a platform to connect businesses in regional and global markets.

“India represents an important and growing dimension of Sohar’s international investment landscape, with established Indian businesses already contributing to our



The Sohar Port is located on the Omani coast on the Gulf of Oman, far from the Strait of Hormuz. FILE PHOTO

industrial ecosystem. There is significant potential to deepen this relationship through investments that complement our industrial clusters, strengthen value chains and create new opportunities for growth,” said Raid Al Rubaiey, CEO of Sohar Freezone and Deputy CEO

of Sohar Port. The port is located on the Omani coast on the Gulf of Oman, and ships can access hubs in the Gulf through this port as it sits far from the Strait of Hormuz.

Mr. Rubaiey said that Sohar Port has received investments of over \$30 billion and that it is capable of

handling 72 million tonnes of cargo annually. “Sohar provides an established industrial and logistics platform connecting businesses to regional and global markets,” he said.

The remarks came at the end of a two-day promotional event organised by the Embassy of Oman, during which the Ambassador of Oman, Issa Saleh Al Shibani, introduced the port and the Freezone to Indian businesses, manufacturers and exporters to increase Indian participation in the port.

Earlier, Oman had offered Duqm and Salalah ports to India, but the Sohar Port has the advantage of being located in the northeast of Oman, close to vital energy pipelines of the United Arab Emirates and eastern Saudi Arabia.

EC calls both Trinamool factions for hearing today

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Election Commission (EC) has called both factions of the Trinamool Congress – one led by former West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee and the other by Leader of Opposition in the Assembly Ritabrata Banerjee – for hearings again on Thursday.

The EC met both factions on Saturday over their claim on the party name and symbol. The poll body had sought additional documents from the Ritabrata faction. In separate letters dated September 16, the poll body asked the Ritabrata team to reach the EC headquarters in Delhi at 3 p.m. and the Mamata-led grouping at 4 p.m.

‘Adivasi School Thik Karo’ drive to be unveiled today: CJP

Press Trust of India
NAGPUR

Alleging that tribal schools in India have been facing government apathy for the last 80 years, Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) founder Abhijeet Dipke on Wednesday announced the launch ‘Adivasi School Thik Karo’ campaign from Gadchiroli in the State from Thursday.

Addressing a press conference here, Mr. Dipke said the campaign is aimed at drawing the government’s attention towards the problems and discrimination faced by tribal students.

A month ago, the CJP launched ‘School Thik Karo’, a nationwide campaign aimed at improving the condition of rural and urban public schools.

Mr. Dipke said, “Schools in tribal regions across India have been neglected by all governments. Therefore, we are starting the campaign from Thursday in Gadchiroli district of Maharashtra.”

Gadchiroli is a tribal-dominated district in eastern Maharashtra’s Vidarbha region.

As part of the exercise,



Abhijeet Dipke

CJP representatives will visit tribal schools and inspect the facilities and infrastructure, he said. “Almost all governments have ignored tribal students... Political parties spend crores of rupees to build their headquarters in every district, but they don’t have funds for tribal residential schools that are mostly operated from rented properties,” Mr. Dipke said.

He also urged the government to focus on students from tribal belts saying that they have a lot of potential. “The government will have to give priority to the tribal community. Just claiming a 7.8 GDP growth rate or talking about becoming a USD 5 trillion economy is not enough,” he said.

Congress demands accountability for deaths of tribal children in M.P.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Wednesday demanded that the Bharatiya Janata Party government in Madhya Pradesh fix accountability for the deaths of more than 35 tribal children in Balaghat and over 50 people in a spurious liquor tragedy in Sagar.

It sought the resignations of the State Health Minister Rajendra Shukla and Excise Minister Jagdish Devda, both Deputy Chief Ministers as well. The party demanded compensation of ₹1 crore for each affected family and a government job for one member from each family.

Addressing a press con-



ference, Adivasi Congress chairperson Vikrant Bhuria and party media panelist Sadhna Bharti alleged that the incidents reflected serious failures in the State’s health and administrative systems.

Mr. Bhuria said more than 35 children in Balaghat had died after suffering from ailments including diarrhoea, malaria, measles and pneumonia. He

Balaghat does not need PR management. It needs nutrition, vaccination, treatment and accountability

VIKRANT BHURIA
Adivasi Congress chairperson

said malnutrition was a major underlying concern and added that people in parts of the district had not received ‘Take Home Ration’ for six months.

Vaccination coverage in some areas, he said, was below 70%, while adequate preventive measures against malaria had not been taken. Questioning the government’s spending on malnutrition, Mr. Bhuria

cited figures provided by the State government in 2025, according to which ₹12 a day was being spent on severely malnourished children and ₹980 for children admitted to nutrition rehabilitation centres.

He questioned whether such allocations were adequate to tackle severe malnutrition.

He alleged that those raising questions over the Balaghat deaths were being pressured. “Balaghat does not need PR management. It needs nutrition, vaccination, treatment and accountability,” he said, adding that the government should establish the causes of the deaths and take steps to prevent their recurrence.

Cong. issues notice to Ratia MLA for ‘anti-party’ conduct

The Hindu Bureau
GURUGRAM

The Haryana Congress Legislature Party (CLP) has issued a show-cause notice to Ratia MLA Jarnail Singh seeking to initiate his disqualification under the anti-defection law for allegedly defying the party whip and engaging in anti-party activities during the Assembly’s Monsoon Session.

The notice, issued by Congress chief whip and Rohtak MLA Bharat Bhushan Batra, asks Mr. Singh to explain why his conduct should not be treated as “voluntarily giving up his membership of the Congress”.

Point-wise response

He has sought a point-wise response to 17 questions and asked Mr. Singh to explain why proceedings for his disqualification should not be initiated.

Mr. Singh, who was elected on a Congress ticket, was among the five MLAs suspended from the party’s primary membership in April for allegedly voting against the party nominee in the Rajya Sab-

Jarnail Singh was among five MLAs suspended from the party’s primary membership in April

ha election.

According to the notice, the CLP had issued a three-line whip on August 27 directing its MLAs to remain present in the House during the session and support an adjournment motion moved by the party. CLP secretary Induraj Narwal was deputed to serve the whip on the members.

The notice cites Mr. Narwal’s report that Mr. Singh refused to accept the whip. It further alleges that although he was present in the House when the motion was taken up, he did not stand in its support along with the other Congress MLAs.

Mr. Singh has also been accused of displaying a placard inside the House and then taking it to the Treasury benches while raising slogans against the Congress with members of the ruling party. Images of the incident have been enclosed with the notice.

INBRIEF



PM Mementos e-Auction's eighth edition begins today

A total of 1,498 gifts received by Prime Minister Narendra Modi will go under the hammer at the eighth edition of the PM Mementos e-Auction, to be held in New Delhi from September 17 to October 31. The e-auction offers citizens, collectors, institutions, and art and culture enthusiasts an opportunity to acquire the unique mementos presented to the Prime Minister on various occasions. The auction would be held through www.pmmementos.gov.in. In this edition, 50 ‘Hero Objects’ have been identified, representing some of the distinctive pieces in the collection, including a Sri Ranganathaswamy Tanjore-style framed painting.

Uttar Pradesh ATS arrests T.N. youth over terror group links

The Uttar Pradesh Anti-Terrorism Squad (ATS) has arrested a 19-year-old youth from Tamil Nadu for alleged involvement in conspiring to carry out “violent jihadist activities” and being part of WhatsApp groups that contained bomb-making videos and material linked to Al Qaeda in the Indian Subcontinent (AQIS). Maqsood Ali, who was allegedly in touch with Pakistani hackers and had developed a secure communication network for others like him, was arrested from Coimbatore on Monday with the assistance of the Tamil Nadu ATS, officials said on Wednesday. This was the second arrest in the case within the last few days. PTI

Delhi HC asks Centre's plan for regulating social media

The Delhi High Court on Wednesday asked the Centre to respond whether it was contemplating formulating a policy to regulate addition-causing design features on social media platforms like infinite scroll and autoplay. A Bench said it would hear a PIL plea seeking constitution of an expert committee to examine engagement-maximising and addiction-causing design features on social media platforms after three weeks. It asked Additional Solicitor-General Chetan Sharma to take instructions on the issue. Mr. Sharma said that it will be in the domain of the policy-makers to consider some of the issues raised in the plea.

Govt. asks cab aggregators to stop advance tipping option

The government has ordered cab aggregators to stop providing advance tipping options even before booking a ride, as the practice is misleading and unfair, Consumer Affairs Secretary Nidhi Khare said on Wednesday. The secretary's comment comes a day after the Central Consumer Protection Authority slapped a ₹10 lakh penalty on ride-hailing platform Rapido for various unfair business practices. The authority is currently examining the business practices of Uber and Ola. Responding to queries related to taxi ride aggregators, Ms. Khare said the National Consumer Helpline has received a lot of complaints against them. PTI

‘Census Town’ definition is outdated: Ministry to panel

Housing and Urban Affairs Ministry says the four-decade-old definition ignores economic change, regional diversity, and peri-urban growth; RGI has decided to continue with it despite objections

Sobhana K. Nair
NEW DELHI

The four-decade-old criteria used to classify Census Towns will not be able to capture the actual scale of urbanisation in India, the Housing and Urban Affairs Ministry told a parliamentary committee, arguing that the present rigid definition, which the Registrar-General of India (RGI) has decided to continue with despite the Ministry's objections, does not account for economic and spatial transformations.

A draft report, “Census Criteria for Defining Urban Areas”, was discussed by the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Housing and Urban Affairs, headed by TDP MP Magunta Sreenivasulu Reddy, on Wednesday. The Ministry, while depositing before the panel, said the old “rural-urban” binary was outdated and inadequate because of the diversity and complexity of economic activity.

The Economic Advisory Council to the Prime Minister (EAC-PM) argues that



Taking count: The Registrar-General of India has said that it was too late to alter the framework for Census 2027. FILE PHOTO

the country's urbanisation level could have been as high as 63% in 2015 based on satellite data – more than double the official Census 2011 estimate of 31%. According to the 2011 Census, out of the total population of 121 crore, around 83.3 crore Indians or nearly 68.8% of people live in rural areas, while 37.7 crore people or 31.2% of the population reside in urban areas

A Census Town is defined as a village with a minimum population of 5,000, at least 75% of the male working population

engaged in non-agricultural pursuits, and a population density of at least 400 persons per sq. km. The definition has remained unchanged since 1981.

Male bias questioned

In a communication to the RGI in February 2024, the Ministry had flagged several issues with the continued use of the 1981 definition. It objected to uniform national thresholds, saying they disadvantaged hilly and northeastern States. The Ministry also questioned the “male bias”, where only the male work-

ing population was being used as a parameter to define a town. The female workforce participation should also be utilised, it said.

The Ministry also said population density was calculated using administrative boundaries rather than built-up areas, resulting in misclassification of settlements. It proposed greater use of satellite imagery and suggested a “transitional areas” category to better capture rapidly urbanising regions.

The Ministry further argued that the binary rural-urban classification overlooked peri-urban settlements and growth corridors that functioned like urban areas. It said the current system, based on data from the previous Census, could lead to both exclusion and inclusion errors. However, the RGI maintained that it was too late to alter the framework for Census 2027, as enumeration blocks, boundaries, training and field deployment depending on the rural-urban classification being finalised in advance.

NEET-UG follow-up: NTA seeks subject experts, translators

Maitri Porecha
NEW DELHI

The National Testing Agency (NTA) has invited applications from experienced educators, researchers, and academics for the empanelment of subject matter experts and translation reviewers as part of its overhaul following the NEET-UG paper leak earlier this year.

The NTA has removed 600 subject matter experts, including external, contracted, and panel-based personnel who were responsible for creating question papers, translating content, and conducting psychometric reviews, after it was found that some of them were compromised and responsible for the leak. They are now being replaced.

The agency has stated that experts can submit their Expressions of Interest on the NTA portal till October 9.

“If you are passionate about maintaining pedagogical excellence, academic integrity, and rigorous assessment standards across India's premier national-level examinations, this is your opportunity to contribute directly to the

National Testing Agency has removed 600 subject matter experts after the NEET-UG paper leak

examination ecosystem,” the NTA said on X.

The NTA is seeking subject matter experts who can contribute to formulation of questions by crafting high-order thinking, and application-based and syllabus-aligned questions, the agency has specified. It is looking for subject matter experts who can conduct review and vetting by scrutinising test items for conceptual accuracy, clarity, and difficulty calibration.

The subject matter experts should be fluent in moderation and ensuring standardisation, neutrality, and adherence to exam blueprints. They should also be sound in translation and “trans adaptation” by providing precise, culturally and linguistically sound translations. Serving or retired faculty, professors, school educators, and domain specialists with demonstrable subject expertise can apply, the NTA has said.

‘Academic freedom severely restricted under current govt.’

Maitri Porecha
NEW DELHI

India's academic freedom has been “severely restricted” under the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) government, according to the annual “Free to Think 2026” report released by Scholars at Risk's (SAR), an international network of higher education institutions that works to protect threatened scholars and promote academic freedom, headquartered at New York University.

According to the report, India's Academic Freedom Index (AFI) score decreased from 0.16 in 2024 to 0.14 in 2026, with both values falling in the “severely restricted” category, next to its neighbours China (0.07) and Afghanistan (0.09), where academic freedom was in the “completely restricted” category.

India's AFI value has declined significantly over the last decade, from 0.41 in 2015.

The AFI is measured on a scale of 0 to 1 and assesses parameters like campus integrity, freedom of academic expression, freedom of academic exchange and dissemination, freedom to research and teach and institutional autonomy.

The report documents 382 attacks arising from 321 verified incidents in 59 countries and territories, as reported by SAR's Academic Freedom Monitoring Project from July 1, 2025, to June 30, 2026. Of the 382, India accounted for the highest number of attacks, with 42 cases, the report noted. These attacks included violence, imprisonment or loss of position of academics or students.

Same-sex partner can be made nominee for medical decisions, Centre tells HC

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Centre has told the Delhi High Court that an adult can nominate a partner, including one in a non-heterosexual relationship, to make medical decisions if they become incapacitated, potentially opening the way for same-sex partners to act for each other despite existing rules not clearly recognising such arrangements.

The submission comes in a case filed by Arshiya Takkar, who has been in a relationship with her partner since 2015 and married her in New Zealand in 2023. Her plea highlighted that in the event of a medical emergency, she could be left without any legal mechanism to make critical decisions for her partner, despite the couple having

Govt. says such a nomination could be subject to applicable law and appropriate safeguards

lived together in Delhi since 2018.

Responding to her plea, the Union Ministry of Health and Family Welfare and the National Medical Commission said that allowing a competent adult to nominate a partner, including one in a same-sex relationship, to take medical decisions in the event of incapacity was “substantially capable of being accommodated within the existing legal and ethical framework”.

“Permitting a competent adult to nominate his/her partner, including a partner in a non-heterosexual/same-sex relationship,

to take medical decisions on his/her behalf in the event of incapacity would constitute a logical and tailored extension of the same principle,” the affidavit said. It added that such a nomination could be subject to appropriate safeguards and the applicable law.

It further submitted that where a competent adult has nominated or otherwise authorised their partner to act on their behalf in the event of incapacity, “there appears to be no medical or ethical rationale for excluding such person merely on account of the sex, gender or sexual orientation of the partners or because their union does not fall within the conventional understanding of marriage..”

The petition is likely to come up for hearing on Thursday.

India remains at 131st rank in global gender parity index

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI/GENEVA

India retained the 131st rank on the Global Gender Gap Index 2026 released by the World Economic Forum on Wednesday, with Iceland, Finland and Norway maintaining their top three slots respectively.

The 14 countries ranked below than India on the index include Papua New Guinea, Kuwait, Oman, Qatar, Tajikistan, Saudi Arabia, Egypt, Morocco, Mali, Algeria, and Congo.

Chad was the lowest-ranked country in the index, with Iran and Pakistan joining it in the bottom three.

For India, the progress towards gender parity stood at 64.5%, below the global average. While India's score improved slightly over the last year, its global ranking remained unchanged at 131st.

**THE CROSSWORD**

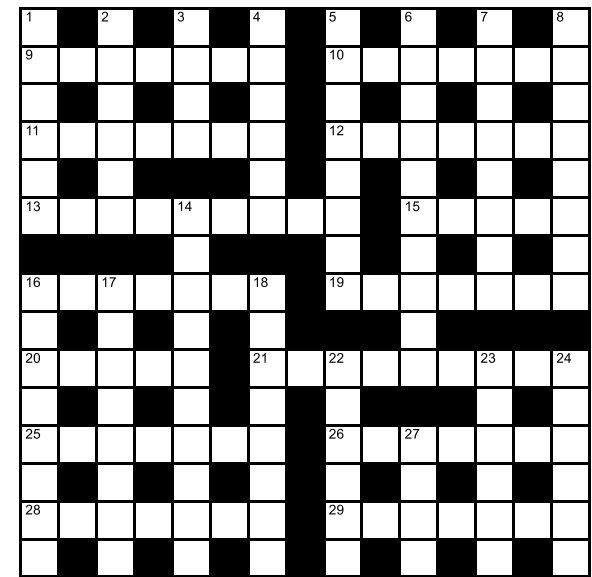
14900

(set by Arden)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>



SCAN TO PLAY



15. Rob on average, shows no anger (5)
16. Country song about soldiers (7)
19. In money collection, company shows thrift (7)
20. Pen stand? (5)
21. Spinner of yarns right in front of a working counter (9)
25. Added about hundred and formed froth on top (7)
26. Drop line for a scapegoat (4,3)
28. Force one to come in and sign up for jury duty (7)
29. Checked regular trend to follow German car (7)
- DOWN**
1. Language of north central Africa fashionable to adopt nowadays (6)
2. Parrot became a bird of prey (6)
3. Feature of a country, in brief (4)
4. Girl takes old boyfriend in her wing (6)
5. Fantastic treasure trove - taking wrong route to cross (8)
6. Adjust dimmers - have to cool it (6,4)
7. American influence on a party and state (8)
8. Banks' same rate - note lady does it calmly (8)
14. Writer's tragic life - one enters China (3,7)
16. Both sides like to secure pole position - wrongdoing is a killer (8)
17. Paul came out to admit mistake (3,5)
18. A terrier gets refreshed with a beer (8)
22. Able to cover the backside with a robe (6)
23. Maybe they can drink one gallon - that's four times score (6)
24. On fourth day, I returned the partly paid up capital (6)
27. Marriage vow by the lake fountain (4)

- ACROSS**
9. Warm layer is savage (7)
10. Capital housing - last letter follows greeting from Ginger, perhaps (7)
11. Relaxation by the river sipping wine (7)
12. Run away velocity of a horny creature (7)
13. Rifleman's job is to protect store (9)

SUDOKU

	2						7
8			5			3	
			4	1		5	
4					3		
2	9		7			4	8
		8					2
7		1	5				
	1			2			4
3						7	

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

Solution to previous puzzle							
S	T	U	D	E	N	A	P
O	N	E		O	T	A	R
E	A	R	O	F		P	I
T	E	T	I	S	E	L	E
C	L	A	P	T	R	A	P
O	S	S	E	N	O	S	E
P	R	O	P	A	G	A	N
Y	N	D	E	R	S	T	R
A	D	O	E	R	S	T	O
S	A	T	A	N	E	N	E
A	U	G	E	R	I	T	A
L	O	N	E	S	M	E	

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku							
9	5	1	4	7	8	2	6
8	2	7	6	3	9	1	4
4	6	3	1	2	5	9	7
2	3	8	7	9	4	5	1
7	9	6	5	1	2	3	8
5	1	4	3	8	6	7	2
1	7	5	8	4	3	6	9
3	8	9	2	6	7	4	5
6	4	2	9	5	1	8	3

FAITH

Devotion of Gopikas

Srimad Bhagavatam explores the supreme devotion of the Gopikas towards Lord Krishna during the Rasa Leela, said Navalpakkam Sri Ramachar in a discourse. On a serene, moonlit autumn night, Lord Krishna decides to engage in divine pastimes with the Gopikas of Vrindavan. To gather them without sending formal messengers, He plays His divine flute. Upon hearing the sweet music, the Gopikas abandon their household chores, families, and sleeping infants, rushing out into the forest in utter haste. When they arrive, Lord Krishna tests their steadfastness by advising them to return home. They say their minds have been completely stolen by His flute song, making it impossible for them to return to worldly life.

Moved by their devotion, Krishna initially grants their wish and joins them in the Rasa Leela, but soon disappears to dissolve any subtle pride (*Ahankara*) within them. Devastated by His sudden separation, the Gopikas wander through the forests of Vrindavan. Unable to find Him, they gather on the banks of the Yamuna and sing the Gopika Geetham, expressing their intense longing and glorifying His divine nature. They glorify His lotus-like eyes and beg for His compassionate glance, making four heartfelt requests: that He place His reassuring lotus hands upon their heads, allow them to behold His smiling face, rest His holy feet – which walked the pastures and conquered Kaliya – upon their hearts, and grant them the nectar of His life-restoring words. Touched by their selfless love and poignant stanzas, Lord Krishna reappears before them. Overjoyed, the Gopikas welcome Him back in various loving ways, completely forgetting their grief.

India has a research blindspot: its own science system

The country needs to invest in metascience, in institutions, expertise, and people whose job is to study how Indian science actually works; it means documenting what has worked and what has not, instead of forgetting it with every change in leadership

Moumita Koley

The U.S. Office of Science and Technology Policy (OSTP) recently released a 125-page policy document titled ‘Science: A New Golden Age’, which presents a renewed vision for American science. It positions itself as a sequel to the American inventor Vannevar Bush’s 1945 report, ‘Science: The Endless Frontier’, which laid the foundations of the famously successful post-war American research system.

As it happens, the new report can be consequential for the Indian science system as well – by revealing the importance of something that India currently does not have but should as quickly as possible: the ability to study its own science system with evidence.

Why a system works

The report starts with a diagnosis well known to the science-of-science, or metascience, research community: despite sustained increases in research and development investment, returns in scientific productivity and innovation have not kept pace. But more than agreement or disagreement with this diagnosis, what matters is that a system should be able to interrogate itself using its own data and be able to reach a conclusion like this.

After its diagnosis, the report draws two conclusions worth exploring. First, it says the U.S. should invest more in individual researchers with bold, high-risk ideas rather than routing funds primarily through what it calls “legacy institutions”. Second, it calls into question the prevailing one-size-fits-all model of research funding, instead advocating for experimenting with alternative funding mechanisms. It also calls for funding agencies to evaluate whether their own mechanisms can be made more effective.

The institutions that fund science should be accountable for the evidence that what they fund and why are actually working – and not just in the U.S. Across Europe, the U.K., China, and Japan, governments and funders are investing seriously in metascience that is able to address this concern. Governments and the people need concrete answers to how their research systems actually function: specifically, how it sets funding priorities, how funding mechanisms perform, how peer-review behaves, how it assesses researchers, how its incentives affect the way scientists collaborate, and so on.

Building a memory

In India, this conversation has barely begun. The country’s science system has historically been shaped by the experience, judgment, and leadership of eminent scientists. That experience is invaluable and must remain a source of evidence – but it is also no longer sufficient considering today’s research ecosystem is far more complex than it was half a century ago, and



The institutions that fund science should be accountable for the evidence that what they fund, and why, are actually working. GETTY IMAGES

understanding it requires systematic analysis. Specifically, it needs to draw on economics, the sociology of science, political science, public policy, organisational studies, scientometrics, and history and philosophy.

An exploration of bibliographic databases shows that, between 1950 and 2024, Indian publications addressing metascience or closely related questions across these domains remained low. Except for scientometrics, Indian research in these areas accounted for only around 1-2% of global research output, with the total number of publications generally not exceeding a hundred over the entire period.

A related problem is institutional memory. As leadership and personnel change, experiential knowledge about what worked, what failed, and why is lost. India has very few publicly available analytical reports documenting the evolution of its research system, and little that carries institutional learning across successive generations of policymakers. Building that memory is itself part of building better science governance, and it is where metascience can have a significant impact.

For these reasons, India needs to invest in scientific research as well as in the capacity to study the ecosystem in which this research happens.

Reason of state

The OSTP report also called for setting clearer national scientific goals to streamline research efforts and speed up the translation of discoveries into technologies, including those for society’s benefit. This, too, is worth taking seriously but also debating carefully because it understates how much of

transformative science begins without any defined mission at all, i.e. as curiosity-driven research. And this, again, is precisely the kind of question a meaningful metascience capacity would allow India to debate with evidence rather than insights alone.

Quantum mechanics emerged in the early 20th century to answer fundamental questions about the nature of matter. It later became the foundation of semiconductors, lasers, and modern computing. Decades of curiosity-driven research in molecular biology, with no application in sight, eventually made CRISPR gene-editing and mRNA vaccines possible. The mathematics underlying today’s artificial intelligence – including neural networks and transformer architectures – emerged from exploratory research in statistical mechanics.

The economist Mariana Mazzucato has documented this pattern in her work on what she calls “the entrepreneurial state”. She has shown that many of the technologies in a single iPhone, including the internet, GPS, touchscreen, and the voice-recognition algorithms behind Siri, have their roots in blue-sky research funded by U.S. federal agencies such as DARPA and the National Institutes of Health. All these were undertaken decades before any company saw commercial application potential in them. In her account, the state was a bold and patient investor that was absorbing risks no private venture would touch. This is the kind of long-horizon, curiosity-driven investment that a purely ‘mission and metrics’ approach to funding – like what increasingly prevails in India today – risks crowding out. But at the same time, mission-oriented research has its own record of delivery. The Apollo programme

forced rapid advances in aerospace engineering, materials science, and computing that spread far beyond the space race. The Human Genome Project turned biology into a coordinated, global, infrastructure-scale enterprise. India itself had the Green Revolution, where crop-breeding research backed by state investment and clear food-security goals transformed the country’s relationship with hunger within a single generation. The Revolution has its own legitimate critics as well, regarding ecological costs, regional inequity, and long-term sustainability. But that very disagreement also makes the case for India to be able to evaluate a mission using evidence.

Striking the balance

A healthy research ecosystem may well need both approaches to research, with research on a mission being used to meet pressing challenges and curiosity-driven, blue-sky research to open new frontiers. It is just that any decision on where to strike that balance should rest on deliberation and evidence, rather than on which topics happen to be fashionable in global policy discourse at a given moment.

To facilitate that, India needs to invest in metascience, in institutions, expertise, and people whose job is to study how Indian science actually works. It means documenting what has worked and what has not, instead of forgetting it with every change in leadership, and building institutions strong enough to imagine an ambitious future for Indian science.

(Moumita Koley is a senior research analyst at the Indian Institute of Science, Bengaluru. moumita.chem@gmail.com)

THE SCIENCE QUIZ

Scientific problems featuring cities

Vasudevan Mukunth

QUESTION 1

The X paradox refers to a game where people get double the payout when a coin lands heads — yet people tend to pay only a small amount to play. The Swiss mathematician Nicolas Bernoulli used this paradox to challenge expected-value theory. Name X.

QUESTION 2

In this game, there are three pegs and discs of increasing size stacked on one peg (with the smallest on top). The goal is to move the whole stack to another peg, one disc at a time, while never placing a larger disc on a smaller one. The game originated in 1883. Name it.

QUESTION 3

The U.S. economist _____ once asked: if you must meet a stranger in New York City tomorrow, with no

way to communicate, where and when would you go? The economist used the question to show how people participating in coordination games are often guided by shared cultural expectations. Fill in the blanks.

QUESTION 4

In 1692, the Italian mathematician Vincenzo Viviani put forth a challenge: cut four equal windows into a hemispherical dome so that the remaining curved surface can be exactly squared, meaning its area can be expressed without using π . This, called the _____ problem, was an important result in geometry. Fill in the blank.

QUESTION 5

Can you double the volume of a cube using only a compass and a ruler? This is one of the classic construction problems, named for the Greek city of Z, which is also the birthplace of Apollo in Greek mythology. Nineteenth century mathematicians proved this is impossible to do. Name Z.

Answers to September 10 quiz:

1. Continent hosting vast majority of world’s glacial ice – **Ans: Antarctica**

2. Warm continent that last had glaciers 19,000 years ago – **Ans:**

Australia

3. Glacier that is site of world’s highest altitude battlefield – **Ans: Siachen**

4. Substance that is mostly locked away in glaciers, ice sheets – **Ans: Freshwater**

5. Country with the most glaciers outside polar regions – **Ans: Pakistan**

First contact:

K.N. Viswanathan | Mansi Rathod | Athul K. | Harsh Kumar | Muhammed Rafid



Visual: Name this city. Its name is part of a famous problem involving seven bridges — one of which is visible to the right here — that Leonhard Euler solved in 1736. GUMEROV ILDAR/PUBLIC DOMAIN



Space agencies are targeting the moon’s south pole region, where permanently shadowed craters are supposed to hold large quantities of water ice. GETTY IMAGES

Cities on the moon may run dry far faster than space barons think

Vasudevan Mukunth

As NASA and China speed up their lunar space programmes, a more-than-temporary human settlement on the moon inches closer to reality. Space agencies with these plans are targeting the moon’s south pole region, where permanently shadowed craters are supposed to hold large quantities of water ice.

In the long-term, entrepreneurs like Jeff Bezos have argued for moving heavy industries to the moon while Elon Musk has said the satellite can support a “self-growing city”. As on the earth, water is at the centre of these plans.

But a new study by two astronomers, Martin Elvis of the Smithsonian Astrophysical Observatory and Jonathan McDowell of Durham University, has thrown up a reality check. The duo has estimated that even if the moon hosted one billion tonnes of water, it would support a population of only one million people for roughly a century if they recycled 98% of it.

The findings were published in *Frontiers in Space Technologies*.

The scientists arrived at this estimate based on calculations of how much water the moon may really hold, how much electricity people and industrial activities consume, how much water a human settlement might need, and how efficiently that water can be reused.

Right now, the exact quantity of water on the moon is a major source of uncertainty, and which scientists are studying using robotic missions like India’s Chandrayaan and China’s Chang’e programmes. One 2022 study of 65 large permanently shadowed craters estimated that eight of them together hold around 34 million tonnes of water.

Against this backdrop, Elvis and McDowell assumed 1 billion tonnes of water as a generous baseline – around 4 lakh Olympic-sized swimming pools – and the demand to amount to 500 tonnes per person per year.

(The duo also estimated that a city of one million inhabitants would require around 2 GW of power, which can be sourced relatively easily from solar panels and nuclear reactors.)

Without recycling, this will sustain a million people for only around two years. But with 98% recycling, they estimated that a million people will deplete a billion tonnes of water in a century, and a lakh people in a millennium.

They also found one million people could have water for a millennium if they recycled the water to the tune of 99.75% – essentially living like the fictitious Fremmen tribe in the ‘Dune’ books and films.

At present, NASA has said it will set up a permanent outpost near the moon’s south pole from the 2030s under its ‘Moon Base’ programme. China’s ‘International Lunar Research Station’ plans for a basic station by 2035 that will be built out in the 2040s.

India itself is planning a crewed landing on the moon by 2040. In August, NASA also invited the Indian Space Research Organisation to participate in the ‘Moon Base’.

Since Elvis and McDowell assumed a minimum population of one lakh for their analysis, the findings don’t apply to short-duration missions or small lunar outposts. But as these outposts expand, the study suggests, the space agencies and the governments behind them may have to treat water on the moon as a strategic resource.

For feedback and suggestions for ‘Science’, please write to science@thehindu.co.in with the subject ‘Daily page’



Currency conundrum

Boosting local currency trade in BRICS is not a simple choice for India

The BRICS New Delhi Declaration shows that progress in enhancing local currency trade has been incremental. The paragraph pertaining to local currency trade acknowledges the efforts of various task forces and committees but falls short of offering any concrete proposals. Recently, the Commerce Ministry indicated that India’s rupee trade with its BRICS partners was limited, with only the UAE and Russia engaged in it. Even those volumes are relatively small. Until recently, Russia had struggled to dispose of the rupees it was accumulating from its exports to India. Some avenues have now opened, with Russia being forced to import petroleum products from India due to Ukraine’s attacks. But that is a trickle. Another option is to treat any BRICS currency as ‘local’. India has already been using the UAE Dirham to pay for Russian oil. However, the latest Declaration’s mention of promoting BRICS local currency trade “while respecting national priorities and acknowledging that there is no one-size-fits-all approach” is telling. Clearly, there are some intra-BRICS issues that need to be addressed. The deliberations are not public, but it would not be surprising if it was India that had emphasised national priorities and raised problems with a “one-size-fits-all” approach. Local currency trade involves several strategic considerations for India.

On the one hand, India would prefer to continue being paid for its exports in dollars. A depreciating rupee ensures that every dollar paid to India results in a higher amount of rupees. As a country looking to boost exports, India would want to retain this advantage. On the other hand, India is also a major importer and would like to pay in relatively cheaper local currencies. It will eventually have to choose. Then there is the fact that China accounts for about two-thirds of all BRICS exports. BRICS local currency trade will largely be trade in the yuan. Relations with China might be thawing now, but India would still be loath to conduct its business in the yuan. It is also important to distinguish between local currency trade and a BRICS currency. While India has so far been cautiously supportive of the former, it has been vocal in opposing a BRICS currency, largely because of China’s likely dominance of such a currency. Then there is U.S. President Donald Trump’s threat of 100% tariffs on countries adopting a BRICS currency. India has displayed a pragmatic approach to dealing with Mr. Trump, and it will not court such tariff threats lightly. Countries such as Iran and Russia have pressing reasons to move away from the dollar. So far, India does not have a convincing enough one, and the New Delhi Declaration reflects that.

Hog in the limelight

The survival of the pygmy hog depends on a thriving ecosystem

The decline of the pygmy hog – the sole surviving species of the genus *Porcula* and the world’s smallest wild suid – is a narrative about the decline of India’s alluvial floodplains. The pygmy hog depends significantly on dense grasslands to feed, conceal itself, and reproduce, so distress among these animals is an indicator of the floodplain suffering degradation. Protecting the pygmy hog can also extend protections to threatened species such as the Bengal florican, hispid hare, hog deer, and greater one-horned rhinoceros. The Assam government was recently right to laud the efforts of a captive breeding programme that increased the pygmy hog population in the State 32-fold in the last three decades. Breeding from a small founder stock while preventing diseases – suids are highly susceptible to swine diseases – and inbreeding requires conservationists to track pedigree, follow biosafety protocols, and condition individuals before release. That said, the species’ survival in the wild depends on the survival of specific ecosystems, and the latter remains a work in progress. The pygmy hog was believed to be extinct by the mid-20th century as floodplains were converted for farms, tea plantations, and flood control infrastructure and were degraded by invasive plants and altered flood cycles, with the unscientific burning of grasslands further fragmenting habitats. A few individuals were rediscovered in 1971, prompting one conservation effort. The current efforts are due to the Pygmy Hog Conservation Programme from 1995.

Even now, the difficulty of spotting and counting these animals means that it is hard to say how many exist in the wild; per the Durrell Wildlife Conservation Trust, there were some 250 individuals in early 2025, with the last surviving natural population in the Panbari grasslands area of the Manas National Park. Since they continue to be threatened, the captive individuals form the insurance group, but even so, the group’s long-term evolutionary fitness is still not guaranteed. Researchers are also alert to the accumulation of harmful gene variants in the population and low genetic diversity, and thus look forward to the pygmy hog’s natural habitats being restored. Alluvial floodplains are dynamic ecosystems; in addition to threats such as land conversion, efforts to ‘save’ them, such as widespread dry-season fires, can still destroy the dense cover the pygmy hog needs. On the other hand, suppressing ecological processes can leave trees and shrubs to turn grassland into woodland. Given the plan to increase the wild pygmy hog population to 300 by 2040, Assam needs to revert the fragmentation of its protected grasslands, especially in Rupahi and Kanchanbari, and to restore buffer zones around the Manas and Orang National Parks and the Sonai Rupai Wildlife Sanctuary.

A section of Hindu nationalists in India has long questioned the national loyalty of its religious minorities. Under attack, Muslims and Christians have often sought to affirm their loyalty to the nation. But in a curious turn of history, the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), a key platform of Hindu nationalism, is now explaining to the world that loyalty to a nation is not determined by the faith traditions of its citizens. “There is no conflict in being Indian and being a citizen of another country for a Hindu,” RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat said. At an event titled Celebrate Oneness/Celebration of Oneness in London, on September 6, 2026, Mr. Bhagwat said: “If British Hindus are good, committed, and true Hindus, there will never be a conflict between British and Bharat interests. If at all that happens, it is obvious that British Hindus will go with Britain. Exceptions may happen, but Hindutva is clear on this. Your *Karmabhoomi* is where your loyalties lie. Your *Janmabhoomi*, or land of your origin or your birthplace, *Punyabhoomi* or *Janmabhoomi*, is where you get your values, and you have to live those values in your *Karmabhoomi*, serving the *Karmabhoomi*. So, Hindutva never asks you to betray your *Karmabhoomi*. You are living there, you are earning there, you are living there,” he said.

Two forms of nationalism
Nationalism is a shared sense among a group of people that they are a group. Broadly, there are two types of nationalism: territorial and cultural. Territorial nationalism supposes that all people who are in a particular place are one. Whether one is Hindu, Christian, or Muslim, everyone who lives in India is Indian, according to this conception. Cultural nationalism, on the other hand, assumes that all people who share a culture are one, regardless of where they live. For instance, it could hold that all Christians, Muslims, or Hindus form one nation, wherever they live.

In real life, it is impossible to enforce such clear notions, because people and ideas move across national borders, which are themselves subject to change over time. Concepts and practices often get mixed up. In the Indian context, the territorial nationalism depicted in Jawaharlal Nehru’s *The Discovery of India* draws upon culture too.

The cultural nationalism that the RSS represents considers all Hindus around the world as one nation, but it also holds strident views about the territory of India. The RSS anthem is the Sanskrit hymn *Namaste Sada Vatsale Matribhume*, underscoring the primacy of territory even while claiming Hindu universalism. Secularists, on the other hand, also draw upon



Varghese K. George

The RSS’s global outreach revealed contradictions in the Sangh’s ideas about the people and territory that make up a nation

the cultural iconography of *Bharat Mata*. The link between culture and territory in the conceptualisation of the nation has never been simple, but it has been further complicated by globalisation and anti-globalisation politics around the world in recent decades. It is this complication that Mr. Bhagwat has been trying to grapple with through his global outreach tour to mark the Sangh’s centenary. On average, around 1.5 lakh Indians give up their Indian citizenship each year to become citizens of another country. They may find themselves caught in the political equivalent of what clinical psychologists term dissociative identity disorder, or split personality disorder. After giving up their Indian passports, they attend meetings such as those addressed by Mr. Bhagwat and those organised by Prime Minister Narendra Modi in various parts of the world, where they chant “*Bharat Mata ki Jai*”. In Australia and the United Kingdom, some of them support India when it plays cricket against their newly adopted motherlands. Not only are they caught between two mothers in terms of their loyalties, but they have also transported their fraternal conflicts from the subcontinent to the new territories. They carry their old battles over sects, castes and religions to their new motherlands.

The ‘internal enemy’ theme
Hindutva’s foundational author, V.D. Savarkar, framed this concern about the split loyalties of those residing in the territory. In *Hindutva: Who Is a Hindu?*, he distinguished between those who are in the territory of India by the accident of birth and those who consider it their sacred land. The true Hindu, in his formulation, is one who has India as both *pitrubhumi* and *punyabhumi*, a test that excludes Muslims and Christians who may have their sacred lands elsewhere. This fear of the resident alien, or even the enemy within, continues to persist in Hindutva thinking. Mr. Bhagwat himself has spoken of this. “This war is not against an enemy without, but against an enemy within. So there is a war to defend Hindu society, Hindu Dharma and Hindu culture. Foreign invaders are no longer there, but foreign influence and foreign conspiracies continue...” he told *Organiser* in an interview in 2023. This theme of the internal enemy continues to animate Hindutva nationalism, at any rate, a vocal section of it. When the RSS says it is spreading the message of the oneness of the world, how does this sit with its notions of territory and people? Is the RSS an organisation meant for all Hindus, wherever they may be in the world, or is it about uniting all Indians? Rather than an easy answer, what one might encounter in the Sangh’s stated principles and

practices are contradictions, and perhaps a struggle to come to terms with a changing world. The Sangh has become a global actor, partly by accident and partly by design. Mr. Bhagwat also maintains that all people who are in India and share the same ancestry are all Hindus. If all people who share the same ancestry are Hindus and part of the nation, there is no reason why the RSS should be anxious about the movement of people from anywhere in the subcontinent. But that is not the RSS’s position, which calls for the stringent protection of Indian borders and the removal of so-called infiltrators by all possible measures. Migrations linked to colonialism dispersed Indians across distant shores. Wherever Indians settled, the anti-colonial movement also took root. Intellectual and organisational strands of the Indian national movement were present in many parts of the world in the early 20th century. In fact, both Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi and Vinayak Damodar Savarkar developed their ideas while living in the United Kingdom.

Diaspora dilemma
The visible emergence of Hindus in the West as a political community in recent decades has been a double-edged sword for Hindutva. The U.K. has had a Prime Minister of Hindu faith, Rishi Sunak. The RSS and the Bharatiya Janata Party introduced a new vocabulary of the *janmabhoomi-karmabhoomi* duet when they launched their diaspora politics under Atal Bihari Vajpayee’s government. This worked quite well in reaching out to western audiences until native nationalisms in the West began to view migrants with suspicion. It so happened that the RSS’s intensive diaspora politics, which became part of India’s state policy under Mr. Modi, coincided with the rise of nativism in the West. Mr. Bhagwat’s London speech sought to address this concern: Can a person of an allegedly foreign faith be a loyal citizen of the country? If this moment is truly one of self-reflection and marks an evolutionary milestone for the RSS in its 100th year, it must apply the same standard everywhere, across the entire *bhumi*. What is true in London must be equally true in Lucknow: loyalty to the nation is not determined by the faith one follows, but by one’s residency and the modern concept of citizenship. Mr. Bhagwat has done well in stating that people of Indian origin must choose their adopted country over India in all situations, echoing Jawaharlal Nehru’s position on this question. However, Mr. Bhagwat’s words will be tested equally in the Indian context if they are to be accepted as a marker of the RSS’s evolution.

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China’s strategy amid West Asia’s security realignment

Chinese President Xi Jinping’s visit to Egypt (September 1-2, 2026) marked a shift in Beijing’s engagement with West Asia. In talks with Egyptian President Abdel Fattah El-Sisi, Mr. Xi set out a four-point formula for a new regional security architecture. Beijing has long talked about the need to rethink regional security, but this is the first time it has elaborated what such an architecture should look like. Among the four points, the first is the need to “unleash the internal momentum of regional common security”. The core component of this is to reduce the “interference by external forces” while supporting regional countries to strengthen dialogue on peace and security. Second, Mr. Xi called for the issues in the region to be discussed comprehensively, while prioritising the goal of a two-state solution for the Palestinian question. Third, he stressed that “lasting stability and security in West Asia relies fundamentally on development”. In doing so, he articulated Beijing’s opposition to the weaponisation of international waterways, while positioning economic diplomacy and development cooperation as the preferred instrument for Chinese engagement. Finally, Mr. Xi insisted that all these efforts must happen through the United Nations framework.

A shifting security order
The announcement comes at an interesting moment in the evolution of West Asian geopolitics. The United States-Israeli war against Iran, the fracturing of Gulf security assumptions, disrupted energy flows and the closure of the Strait of Hormuz, and rising Türkiye-Israel tensions have all pressed on Chinese interests. Pakistan’s brokering of a U.S.-Iran understanding, which Beijing supported, offered a template for extending influence without exposure. Then came the Mecca Joint Defence Agreement on August 7, 2026 between Pakistan, Saudi Arabia and Türkiye. In theory, a North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO)-style mutual defence agreement would



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The Chinese President’s visit to Egypt has outlined Beijing’s approach

not be welcome in Beijing. Over the years, the Chinese leadership has repeatedly pushed back against what it says is Cold War mentality and bloc politics. But in this case, it has been extremely cautious. There has been no formal comment, no direct leadership statement, and no word from its ambassadors. That, however, does not mean that there has not been an internal debate.

Mecca pact, Chinese views
For instance, Long Chen of Renmin University’s Chongyang Institute has argued that the Mecca pact might actually serve American purposes. Every administration since (then) U.S. President Barack Obama has sought to shed direct security costs, the 2025 National Security Strategy says as much explicitly, and regional states arming themselves is precisely what offshore balancing requires. He noted that all three signatories remain dependent on American weapons and intelligence. Of course, what all of this ignores is the difficult security relationship that Mecca pact members have with Israel, a key American ally in the region. Others such as Zhou Li, a former Vice-Minister of the International Department of the Central Committee of the Communist Party of China has argued that the pact is an exercise of regional strategic autonomy, produced by the erosion of American hegemony, and consonant with China’s Global Security Initiative. Mr. Zhou has contended that comparing this agreement to a NATO-style treaty is foolhardy, as there is no published text, no joint command, no cost-sharing, and no binding obligation. Essentially, Mr. Zhou concludes that such a pact dilutes American primacy without creating a rival bloc that Beijing would have to position itself against. Mr. Zhou also suggested that the next member to join the agreement could be Egypt, which is where Mr. Xi’s statement and the choice of venue for it are significant. In calling to “unleash the internal momentum of regional common security”, Mr. Xi seems to have weighed

in on the domestic debate, leaning in favour of Mr. Zhou’s argument. What likely prompted him to do so is the belief that while Washington remains the preponderant military power in the region, its ability to defend allies against Iranian strikes, to enforce its will in the Strait, and to sustain commitment as its dependence on Gulf energy declines are all now open questions. Gulf states are, therefore, hedging, buying insurance from Pakistan and others. In other words, the American credibility problem has become an opportunity too juicy to miss out on. This is a moment during which Beijing can throw cautious support behind attempts among regional actors to pursue autonomy, with little practical cost to itself.

Beijing’s interests
China has significant economic and energy stakes in West Asia. If regional states are building their own architecture, Beijing can support the process economically and remain militarily disengaged. It already has substantial defence and technology trade with Pakistan, growing ties with Saudi Arabia, and openings in Türkiye and Egypt. Saudi Arabia and Egypt together absorbed roughly a third of China’s combat drone deliveries in the decade to 2023, according to Stockholm International Peace Research Institute (SIPRI) data. Riyadh has also built domestic solid-fuelled ballistic missile capacity with Chinese technical assistance and is increasingly attracting Chinese technology investment. So there could be money to be made and influence to be cemented in terms of defence and technological engagement. In essence, the formula announced by Mr. Xi in Cairo is a significant position being articulated with regard to the emerging security framework in West Asia. Whether this framework will demand certain guarantees that China remains reluctant to offer is something that must be noted going forward. More interestingly, it seems that despite all the friction, Beijing and Washington might be able to find some common ground in West Asia.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

The UPI charge
It is strange that at a time when India’s UPI has gained wide acceptance both at home and abroad, a 0.4% charge is being introduced on merchant transactions above ₹2,000. The government says about 96% of merchant transactions will remain free, leaving only 4% to bear the new charge. This

raises a basic question: what sizeable amount is expected to be gained from this measure? The answers are not clear. There is also a risk that some merchants may find ways around the charge. They could ask customers to pay into their personal accounts, which remain free, instead of their business accounts, or ask

them to split a large payment into smaller amounts of ₹2,000 or less. Others may simply pass the cost on to customers by raising their prices. UPI has made everyday payments simple for millions. There is little sense in complicating a system that has worked so well. **V. Nagarajan**, Chennai

Weaponised space
The disclosure by the United States that it possesses counter-space capabilities, although it has not revealed their nature, could open the floodgates to the weaponisation of space. While orbital bombardment has so far remained largely within the realm of science fiction, the deployment of kinetic or

non-kinetic conventional weapons in space could make it a reality. This could trigger an arms race, with space powers deploying their weapons in orbit. At a time when the global space industry is seeking cheaper and more affordable technologies for conducting space missions, an arms race in space could hinder progress towards reducing

satellite-launch costs. It could also undermine scientific missions, including exploration and research, as countries divert resources towards weapons rather than scientific advancement. **Kunal Anand**, Bhubaneswar, Odisha
Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Mining amendment is unfair to States

India's mineral wealth is not evenly spread across the country. States such as Odisha, Jharkhand, Chhattisgarh, and Karnataka possess enormous reserves of coal, iron ore, and other minerals that feed industries across India. While mining brings in investment and employment, it also leaves the host State to deal with challenges such as the resettlement of displaced groups; environmental damage; pressure on public infrastructure; and the long-term consequences of extracting minerals that can never be replaced.

That is why the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Act (MMDR), 2026 deserves closer attention. At the heart of the amendment is Section 9D which restricts State Governments from imposing taxes, cesses or other levies on mineral rights or mineral-bearing land except in accordance with conditions prescribed by the Central government. The Centre says the measure is intended to create a predictable tax environment, prevent excessive levies, and to encourage long-term investment in mining. There is an understandable economic argument behind that objective. Mining projects involve enormous investments and operate over decades; investors need to know that the financial rules will not change unpredictably from one year to another. However, this logic has been contested by the States.

The real question is not merely whether States will continue receiving the royalty, the auction premium and other



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revenues they receive today. The Centre claims that 90% of mining sector revenue accrues to the States and that this will continue. The larger concern is about what States may be prevented from earning tomorrow.

A mineral-rich State possesses a natural economic advantage. Ordinarily, one would expect it to have some ability to use that advantage to raise resources for its own development. Section 9D substantially reduces that freedom by making future State levies related to minerals dependent upon a framework controlled by the Centre. This matters enormously for States whose budgets are closely connected with mining. NITI Aayog's Fiscal Health Index has highlighted the strong performance of Odisha and Chhattisgarh in mobilising revenue and has specifically recognised the role played by mining receipts. In Odisha, mining has accounted for a large proportion of the State's non-tax revenue. Mineral producing districts often require greater public expenditure because they bear the costs of mining.

The federal problem

The constitutional issue is equally significant. The Constitution gives States the power to tax mineral rights under Entry 50 of the State List, although Parliament can impose limitations on that power through laws relating to mineral development. States also possess a separate constitutional power to tax lands and buildings under Entry 49 of the State List.

In 2024, a nine-judge Bench of the Supreme Court in *Mineral Area Development Authority vs. Steel Authority*

of India held, among other things, that royalty payable on minerals is not a tax. It also recognised the States' legislative power to tax mineral rights and held that mineral-bearing land can fall within the States' taxation power over land. The 2026 Amendment risks rendering the impact of this judgment nugatory.

While Entry 50 permits Parliament to place limitations upon State taxation on mineral rights, Section 9D of the amending statute goes further by extending its restriction to taxes or levies on mineral-bearing lands. That is likely to raise an important debate: how far can a Central law dealing with mineral development restrict a State's exclusive power to tax land? The issue is larger than mining policy alone. It concerns the relationship between the Union and the States.

India's federal system cannot function effectively if States have responsibilities without financial capacity. A State that bears the infrastructural and social consequences of mineral extraction must retain a meaningful stake in the economic value generated from its natural resources. Uniformity may make taxation more predictable, but predictability should not come at the cost of narrowing the fiscal choices available to States.

The debate over the MMDR Amendment should therefore not be reduced to a contest between promoting investment and imposing taxes. The minerals beneath a State's soil may serve the entire country, but the costs of extracting them are felt most directly by the people who live above them.

What India's growth really means

India's 7.8% real GDP growth in April to June 2026 is an extension of a strong economic journey – real GDP grew 7.2% in 2023-24, 7.1% in 2024-25, and 7.7% in 2025-26. The latest rate exceeds the RBI's 7% forecast despite the West Asian conflict, high energy prices, and uncertain trade. Its real significance, however, lies in the breadth of production and demand.

Real GDP, which is the value of goods and services after adjusting for inflation, rose to ₹81.36 lakh crore, while real GVA, the value added by farms, factories and services before adjusting for product taxes and subsidies, grew by 8.2% to ₹73.82 lakh crore. Manufacturing rose by 9.2%, utilities 8.9% and construction 7.7%, lifting the secondary sector by 8.6%. Services grew by 10%, led by finance, real estate, IT and professional services at 12.1%. Agriculture grew by 3.6%, although mining contracted by 2.4%. This is broad-based growth with identifiable weak spots.

This strength is reinforced by demand. Gross fixed capital formation grew by 11.9%, private consumption by 7.1% and real exports 12%. Using the same gross fixed capital formation measure for 2023-24, investments by private corporations were 10.3% of GDP. While the general government invested 4.2%, total public sector investment was 7.8% when adding in investments by public corporations. Moreover, when adding in household investments, mainly housing and unincorporated businesses, total non-public investment was 24.1% of GDP. That is, while public capital



Gourav Vallabh

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expenditure has built the platform, the next acceleration requires more private investment.

Fast growing economy

The base year change is simple. A base year removes inflation and reflects the economy's structure. Updating it from 2011-12 to 2022-23 replaces an outdated market basket with today's products, services and prices. Some estimates may rise and others fall, but changing the ruler does not shrink the economy. On comparable year-on-year data, India's 7.8% exceeded Malaysia's 6%, Singapore's 5.9%, Indonesia's 5.29%, and China's 4.3%.

India is therefore among the fastest growing major economies. Its expanding market supports global demand for energy, technology, machinery and services, while offering a trusted location for diversified supply chains. This advances India's path to becoming the world's third largest economy in nominal terms. Since rankings also reflect prices and exchange rates, the milestone will endure only if real growth leads to higher productivity, stronger firms, and better household incomes. Employment is the decisive test. India added 17.19 crore jobs between 2014-15 and 2023-24, according to RBI KLEMS-based data. The next employment revolution must improve job quality through productivity, wages, formalisation, social security and skilling. While women's labour force participation reached 41.7% in 2023-24, safe transport, affordable childcare, flexible work, credit and market access are essential to bring many more women into

productive employment.

Manufacturing must move from assembly to design, components, machinery, electronics and clean technology, while services must spread beyond metros into tourism, health, education, logistics, finance and Indian language digital businesses. AI preparedness must move from adoption to original capability through domestic compute, Indian language data, research talent, and trusted applications. India must also make proper use of Free Trade Agreements (FTAs). An FTA utilisation mission should guide firms on rules of tariffs and markets. MSMEs need hand-holding on non-tariff barriers through shared testing, affordable certification, standards, customs support and buyer discovery. Moreover, external ambition requires domestic resilience. India should counter energy risks through diversified suppliers, long term contracts, strategic reserves, renewables, domestic exploration and efficiency. Timely infrastructure, predictable regulation, easier credit, and stable taxation can crowd in private investment.

The 7.8% quarter warrants confidence, not complacency. India must convert public capital expenditure into private investment, job numbers into quality employment, and FTAs into opportunities for MSMEs. If energy and macroeconomic stability accompany inclusion, productivity, and transparent measurement, becoming the third largest economy will be more than a statistical milestone. It will become a foundation for broad-based prosperity.

SIR deletions: elector numbers in 1/3 of Delhi below poll turnout

The number of electors left in the roll – 94.9 lakh – is 97% of the total number of actual voters who turned up to vote in the 2025 elections

DATA POINT

Pon Vasanth B.A.
Devvyanshi Bihani
Srinivasan Ramani

In more than one third of the 70 constituencies in Delhi, the number of deletions following the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) process has been so high that the draft roll in these seats have been left with fewer electors than the actual number of those who voted in the February 2025 Assembly elections.

If one were to trust that the Election Commission (EC) process has been fair, one should believe in the following astounding possibilities: that everyone who has been deemed to be an “ordinary resident” in these 24 constituencies had voted; a significant chunk who voted are no longer there; and that those who did not vote during the 2025 polls were not ordinarily resident then or have ceased to be so in the 17 months between the polls and the commencement of the SIR. In other words, these constituencies witnessed inward and outward migrations of enormous scale in this period alone.

However, there are no signs that any of these things happened. In such a situation, it stands to reason that in merely a year and a half since the Assembly elections, conducted by the EC itself, the changes would not be so dramatic that deletions would entail the electorate to reduce to a number lower than the turnout figures.

Since the draft enumeration process involves electors listing their EPIC numbers and their eligibility to vote in the elections, it stretches reason to assume that the recent voters deemed themselves as ineligible.

This is just the draft roll, and there is still time for electors to be added to the lists – both freshly eligible ones and others who have been erroneously deleted from the rolls. But the slapdash nature of

the SIR process is evident in the fact that the Union Territory has now been left with only 97.5 lakh electors in the draft roll.

Evidence from elections

In February 2025, the electoral rolls had 1.56 crore electors, of which 94.9 lakh electors turned out to vote.

This number in the draft rolls follows two stages of culling names – one prior to the SIR when close to 11 lakh electors were deleted and later, the draft SIR phase when nearly 47.6 lakh electors were deleted (Chart 1).

The Tughlakabad constituency is where the SIR process has made the deepest cut in these terms. In the current draft rolls, there are only 1,00,386 electors, which is 14,575 fewer than the 1,14,961 voters who actually turned out to vote in 2025.

Chart 3 lists 15 of the 24 constituencies in Delhi which have fewer electors now than the actual turnout in 2025. This oddity is most pronounced in the eastern, central and southern parts of Delhi; highest especially in seats beyond the Yamuna river on the east.

The number of electors left in the roll – 94.9 lakh – is 97% of the total number of actual voters who turned up to vote in the 2025 elections with just a “buffer” of around 2.6 lakh electors to leave room for those who were ordinary residents, but did not turn out to vote.

In other words, if all the deletions since the Assembly polls are legitimate, based on the draft rolls, now, the hypothetical turnout percentage would be an implausible 97% (Chart 2).

Interestingly this pattern of leaving a small “buffer” of electors is more marked for States and UTs who have undergone the SIR in Phase 3 – Andhra Pradesh (8.8%), Karnataka (13.1%), Maharashtra (16.2%) and so on. In other words, as the SIR went from phase to phase, the pattern of deletions left fewer “buffer” electors, with Delhi being the “worst” case.

Numbers that do not add up

The data for the charts were sourced from publicly available information on the websites of the Election Commission of India. For Chart 2, turnout figures of 2024 LS polls or Assembly elections in respective States / UTs, whichever happened closer to SIR, were taken for analysis



CHART 1: Of the 1.56 crore electors who were on the rolls before the Delhi Assembly polls in February 2025, 94.9 lakh had voted. Since then, over 58.5 lakh names have been removed

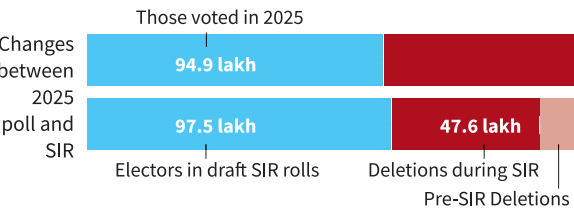
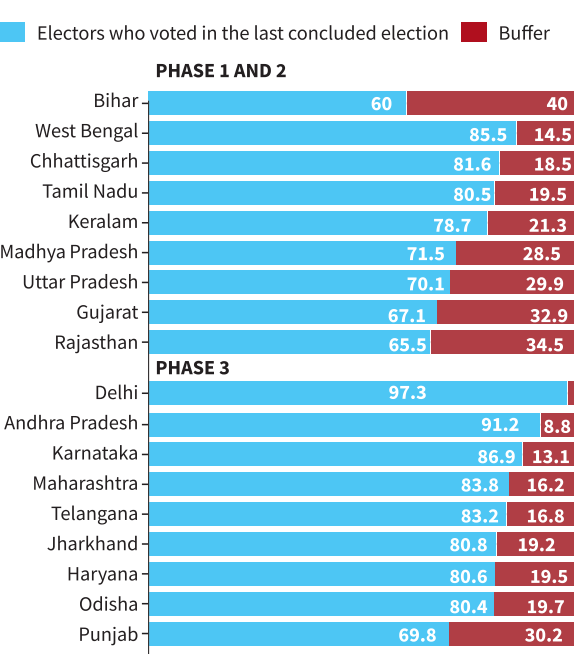
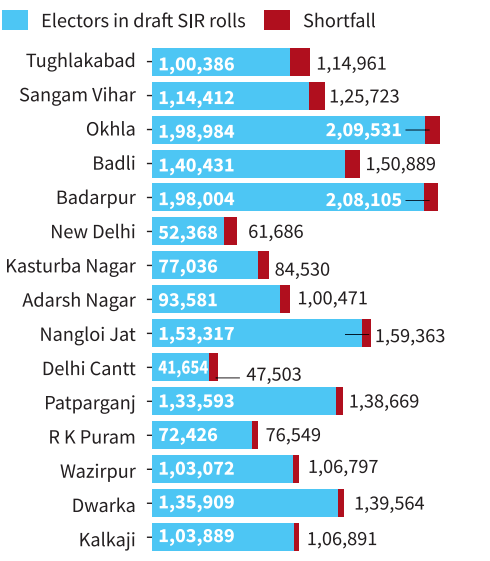


CHART 2: The share of those who voted in the elections before SIR, compared with the electors in the draft SIR rolls. The “buffer” has shrunk noticeably in Phase 3 of the SIR

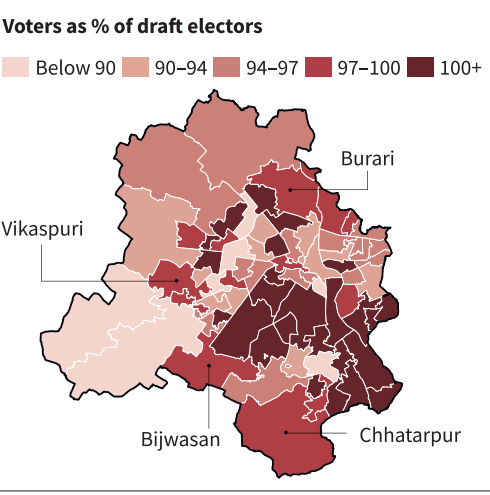


‘Buffer’ indicates the share of draft SIR rolls which includes eligible electors who did not vote in the last election, but continue to remain ordinary residents of the respective places. A narrow buffer of 2.6% in Delhi indicates high possibility of aggressive deletions and potential disenfranchisement of eligible voters

CHART 3: The 15 constituencies with the highest shortfall in the draft SIR rolls when compared with actual voters (shown outside the bars) in the 2025 polls



MAP 1: This shows those voted in 2025 as a share of electors in draft SIR rolls. 100% or more means those ACs have fewer electors than those who voted in 2025



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 17, 1976

Calicut customs hunt for hidden gold

Calicut, September 16: The Calicut customs are trying to unearth gold biscuits worth lakhs of rupees suspected to have been hidden in a big tank in the midst of paddy fields at Poyilkavu, near Quilandy, for the last 20 years. A bund has been built across the tank and water is being pumped out to-night and the authorities hope to strike pay dirt to-morrow evening.

Mr. Dayasankar Karanth, Assistant Collector of Customs, who is in charge of the operation, said that in 1956 the customs had made a big haul of smuggled gold biscuits from the Kaapiad shore (the famous coastal point where Vasco da Gama landed) worth about Rs. 20 lakhs then. It was a big catch and came to be known as “Kaipad seizure.” The gold biscuits, in cloth jackets, had been tied to rocks under seawater about a furlong from the shore. Intelligence reports since then had indicated that part of this smuggled gold had already been removed to shore before the customs men got scent of it and been dumped into the tank.

About six months ago, according to a report, a group of nearly dozen men tried to dig this gold out from the tank without the knowledge of the owner of the tank. On the first night they almost succeeded but the appearance of a snake terrified them and put them off. The next night also they made a secret attempt with the help of a ‘manthravadi’ to scare the snake away but they met with no success.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO SEPTEMBER 17, 1926

Mystery of magnetism

Calcutta, September 17: An interesting discovery, which promises to throw light on the mystery of magnetism and its relation to Chemistry has been made by Professor C.V. Raman, F.R.S, and his associates in the research in Calcutta. By using highly sensitive refined optical methods, it has been demonstrated that molecules of all common liquids, or paraffin for instance, when placed in a strong magnetic field, orientats and tend to place themselves, so that certain favoured directions are parallel to the field. Investigation shows every molecule in its liquid state to possess different magnetic properties in different directions and actually enables these differences to be measured and connected with the chemical structure of molecules.

THE HINDU

11,000

Karnataka Minister Krishna

Byre Gowda on Wednesday launched a drive to shift over 11,000 seized vehicles from police station premises across the city to seven designated locations, aimed at clearing the premises and easing inconvenience to the public. PTI

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An artist rendering released by NASA shows NASA's Voyager 1 spacecraft barreling through space.. FILE PHOTO

What Voyager’s journey tells us about the purpose of exploration

Three books revisit the journey of humanity’s longest-running spacecraft through the solar system to ask what drives our curiosity, to what end, and what it tells us about our place in the universe

Vasudevan Mukunth

Come November, Voyager 1 will be around one light-day away from the earth. That means light will take one day to travel from our home planet to the spacecraft. The Voyager missions are two identical spacecraft NASA launched in 1977 to explore the outer planets. Voyager 1 and Voyager 2 made historic flybys of Jupiter and Saturn; Voyager 2 also visited Uranus and Neptune. Both spacecraft later became humankind’s most distant operating probes. Today, Voyager 1 is at the outer limits of the solar system, and has been for a few years. The spacecraft had to travel at 17 km/s on average for roughly 17,900 days just to get to the picket fence at the end of its little neighbourhood – a day’s journey for light. On the other hand, our telescopes have captured breathtaking visuals of distant celestial wonders, from the Pillars of Creation to the Orion Nebula, from the Sombrero Galaxy to Hoag’s Object, thousands to millions of lightyears away. It is entirely possible humans may never see them up close firsthand, but who knows what the future will bring?

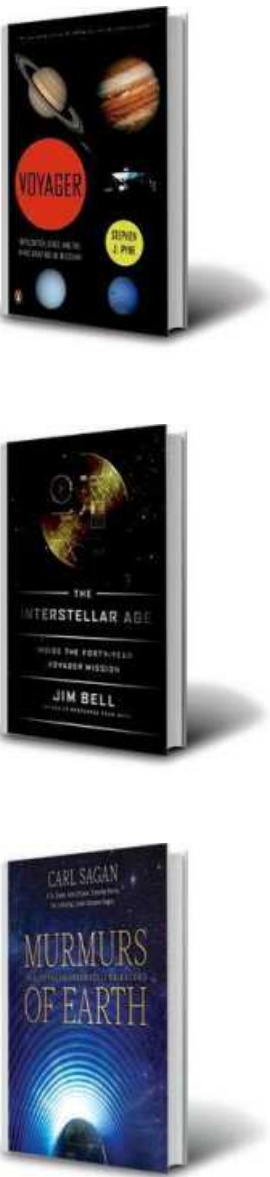
Looking back
In his 2010 book *Voyager: Exploration, Space, and the Third Great Age of Discovery*, historian Stephen Pyne divides writers on exploration into “lumpers” (who look for grand, unifying patterns across history) and “splitters” (who focus on the unique, specific characteristics of

individual expeditions, nations, or eras). The proto-lumpers, he says, hold that humans’ urge to explore lies somewhere in the genome itself; that it is providential. But where Pyne’s book really shines is when it takes a closer look at those who elected to not explore, unearthing how history shaped the ways in which we think about exploration today. Ming China launched seven magnificent fleets before curtailing oceangoing. He writes, “Medieval Islam sponsored great travellers before shrinking into the ritual pilgrimage of the haj. The Norse spanned the Atlantic, then withered on the fjords of Greenland.” According to Pyne, exploration is not some kind of anthropological necessity but an institution sustained by certain rivalries. Like the Aborigines of Oceania, he went on, “Plenty of peoples ... felt little urgency to search beyond the daunting seas or looming peaks.” It can be a dispiriting notion. Exploration is what we do when we rise above the squalor and the misery. Or is it? Pyne guides readers to a more special, and somehow more comforting, thought: that exploration could be all that it has been purported to be if it provides a journey into a wider moral universe that helps us understand who a people are and how they should behave. And you can have this experience as much on the shores of Neptune’s rings as with, to borrow from Rainer Maria Rilke, the “great wide sounds” of the sea crashing down over you at the beach.

The Interstellar Age, by planetary

scientist Jim Bell, recounts a kindred example: the story of how Voyager 1 nearly did not take the Pale Blue Dot image. The picture, for which Voyager 1 had to turn back towards the sun while risking damage to its cameras so it could photograph the earth, had no scientific content – yet it is arguably the mission’s most consequential yield. The astronomer Carl Sagan, upon beholding it, came to his famous conclusion about how we should treat each other. **Our place in the universe** Scarcity is an important part of how we have come to understand exploration: we are told the mind can afford to rise above squalor only after there is no squalor at all, that we must choose between bread or roses. But Bell explains how Voyager 1 itself cost only around one dime per American person per year over its lifetime. Almost always, there is enough for bread as well as roses. This goes for India, too, where necessitous spending by the government on the space programme has become something of a bogeyman. In fact, as the Pale Blue Dot image, among many others, illustrated, the mission delivered to humans an inestimable gain: a sense of place in the universe. As if extending that sense, *Murmurs of Earth: The Voyager Interstellar Record* is pointed in its assertion that the Voyagers’ Golden Records were designed to “join a commonwealth of space-faring societies”. Each Golden Record was a copper disc

plated with gold, containing sounds, music, images, and greetings from the earth in 55 languages (including Tamil and Telugu), plus instructions to locate the planet. For being co-written by Sagan, who also chaired the committee that selected the Records’ contents, *Murmurs* remains a relatively obscure book, in part because it went out of print two decades ago. Its text recounts how the Golden Records were made and why they contain the information they do, written by the people who built them. And it says that this team agreed to exclude mentions of war, disease, crime, and poverty. As the American science journalist Jon Lomberg (who also co-authored *Murmurs*) says in *The Interstellar Age* about what kind of influence the team wanted the Records to have: “It was like asking ourselves, ‘Could we measure up to the Voyager Record?’ This is us at our best, or at least not at our worst. This approach made the record aspirational...”. But if *Voyager* is any guide, the aspiration is also paradoxical: if rivalry is the most reliable engine of a great age of exploration, a pacified, egalitarian world simply may not explore. In the end, nothing can implicitly justify the impulse to explore because it is never just an impulse. It is always purposeful, and thus needs to be collectively owned, internationally authored, unenclosed, and answerable to the people paying for it, even if – or especially if – it inspires them.



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

“Hi, come on in. Did you get a cake from your neighbour this morning?”
“Why should she give me a cake?”
“Today is Christmas; that’s why! Doesn’t she usually give you a big cake?”
“Yeah, she does. But this year, she’s celebrating Christmas in Goa.”
“That’s nice. But is that the reason you’re looking so grumpy? The fact that you didn’t get a Christmas cake?”
“No, I am not angry about that. I am angry with your friend Sujatha. We had another one of our fights.”
“You and Sujatha fighting again! Was it about some silly movie?”
“No, it was about the word ‘handsome’?”
“The word ‘handsome’, eh? Did she insult you by calling you ‘handsome’?”
“Even if I were the last man on earth she would never call me that and you know it. No, the argument was over whether a woman could be called ‘handsome’. I said that the word handsome could be used only with men. She argued that a woman could be called handsome as well. So, tell me. Is she right? Or am I right?”
“She is, actually.”
“What? You mean I can tell someone that Shanti is a handsome woman.”
“Well, I wouldn’t use the word handsome with a young girl like Shanti. You see, mature women can be called ‘handsome’, not young girls.”
“So when you call a woman handsome, are you implying that she is manly?”
‘No, no! Handsome does not mean manly. When you refer to a woman as being handsome, what you are implying is that her features are fairly large and regular rather than pretty and delicate.’
“.... in other words, she is not much to look at.”
“On the contrary, she is very pleasant to look at. The famous Swedish actress Greta Garbo was often referred to as being ‘breathtakingly handsome’.”
“So a woman who is fairly well-built, has big eyes and a big nose is more likely to be called ‘handsome’ rather than pretty?”
“You know what they say, beauty lies in the eye of the beholder.”
“The next time I see Sujatha I have to tell her that she was right. I hate doing that. Tell me, what have you been up to?”
“Oh, nothing much actually. I have been trying to psych my new boss out.”
“Psych your new boss out?”
“The expression has several meanings. One of the meanings of ‘psych someone out’ is to try and figure the person out.”
“In other words, you try and understand the person. How his mind works. Is that what you are saying?”
“Exactly! Here’s an example. No matter how hard I tried, I just couldn’t psych Janaki out. She’s a bit....”
“...I don’t think anyone can psych her out. Anyway, tell me what are the other meanings of psych out?”
“When you psych out about something, you become very excited about it. You may even lose control over your ability to think.”
“When the students came to know that Sachin was to be the chief guest at the Annual Sports Day event, they all psyched out.”
“But later when the students came to know that it was going to be the Chief Minister and not Sachin who was going to be the chief guest, everyone was disappointed. No one psyched out.”
“That is to be expected, I guess.”
Published in *The Hindu* on December 25, 2001

THE DAILY QUIZ

Hashim Thaçi, the former president of Kosovo, has been sentenced to 25 years in prison for war crimes by a tribunal in The Hague. A quiz on other such leaders

Joan Sony Cherian

- QUESTION 1**
Thaci was convicted by the Kosovo Specialist Chambers of The Hague. What is the mandate of these Chambers?
- QUESTION 2**
Which sitting Prime Minister currently has an arrest warrant against him issued by the International Criminal Court (ICC) in 2024?
- QUESTION 3**
This British supermodel once testified in a trial against this former Liberian president at the Special Court for Sierra Leone in The Hague. Name the

- supermodel and the Liberian leader.
- QUESTION 4**
In 2023, the ICC issued an arrest warrant against Russian President Vladimir Putin for war crimes in Ukraine. Along with Putin, it also issued a warrant for another Russian official. Name the individual.
- QUESTION 5**
In 2016, this leader was convicted by the ICC to 18 years’ imprisonment for war crimes and crimes against humanity committed in the Central African Republic. However, the leader was ultimately acquitted by the court after an appeal. Name the leader and his current position.



Visual question:
This leader became the first ex-head of state to stand trial before an international court since World War II. However, he died before judgment could be delivered. Name him. AFP

- Questions and Answers to the previous day’s daily quiz:**
1. Name the British Antarctic Survey scientists whose 1985 paper reported the Antarctic “ozone hole”? **Ans: Joe Farman, Brian Gardiner and Jon Shanklin**
 2. What 1985 international treaty, signed by 20 countries and the European Economic Community, established the framework for later ozone regulations? **Ans: The Vienna Convention for the Protection of the Ozone Layer**
 3. When did the Montreal Protocol enter into force? **Ans: January 1, 1989**
 4. Who is often called the “father of the Montreal Protocol” for his role as UNEP’s head in brokering the deal? **Ans: Mostafa Kamal Tolba**
 5. What 2016 amendment added a phase-down of hydrofluorocarbons under the Protocol? **Ans: The Kigali Amendment**
- Visual: Identify this French physicist. **Ans: Charles Fabry**
Early Birds: K.N. Viswanathan | Prem Raj P. | Aanchal Lakra | Lalchand Bhutani | Sunil Madhavan

Correction: The answer to Question 4 in the Ganesha quiz is Siddhi and Riddhi and not as published. The error is regretted.

Word of the day

Nugatory:
having no purpose or value

Synonyms: empty, worthless, vain, futile, useless

Usage: The criticism was nugatory and was quickly forgotten.

Pronunciation: newsth.live/nugatory

International Phonetic Alphabet: /njuːɡətəri/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject ‘Text & Context’

GM’s EV-first bet leaves it on sidelines of U.S. hybrid boom



Wrong bet: GM’s U.S. market share dropped to 16.8% in the first half of the year, from 17.6% a year prior. REUTERS

Reuters
DETROIT

Florida car dealer Bill Wallace says a majority of customers lately are asking about hybrid options, eager for relief from high gasoline prices.

Salespeople at his 16 dealerships – including Hyundai, Kia and Mazda – have plenty to talk about. But not at his Chevrolet and Cadillac stores. Those General Motors brands each have a broad selection of fully electric cars, but the automaker has only one hybrid model: the Corvette sports car.

GM is sitting out a hybrid boom. The top-selling automaker in the U.S. bet bigger than most competitors on electric vehicles, sales of which have fallen in the wake of anti-EV policies implemented by the Trump administration.

So far, investors have cheered GM’s focus on gas-engine trucks and SUVs, which have fuelled strong profit and a near-record stock price. But its U.S. sales have declined this year, and some dealers say they are losing customers to rivals who offer hybrids.

“There’s no question that they’re losing market share,” Wallace said.

A GM spokesperson said its “strategy is to build a stronger, more profitable business by delivering vehicles customers love.”

Hybrid sales, gas prices soar

Consumer interest in hybrids – which combine a gas engine with a battery and electric motor to save fuel – has surged since the Iran war, which began in late February, sending gas prices up about 40%.

Hybrids accounted for 19% of total U.S. retail vehicle sales in August, up from around 16% in the months before the war started. In May, they hit 20%, or one in five cars sold. Hybrids sold off dealer lots more than twice as fast as non-hybrid gas cars during the second quarter, according to JD Power.

GM executives long maintained that hybrids add too much cost and complexity, and that they preferred to invest in EVs based on a conviction that the market eventually would go all-electric.

GM CEO Mary Barra at a 2019 Barclays conference called hybrids an “interim solution.”

“Customers generally aren’t interested in hybrids,” she said, adding that GM wanted to move straight to EVs to help the environment.

By late 2024, when it was clear that EV sales were not taking off as expected, Barra said the automaker would have plug-in hybrids for the North American market by 2027. This month, she told Fortune that the automaker would have hybrids in important segments, but did not provide a time frame.

Supplier sources and forecasting firms project that GM will not have a hybrid on sale in the U.S. until near the end of the decade. A GM spokesman declined to comment.

Other automakers have struggled with their EV sales, but most have some hybrids to fall back on, and some are looking to add more.

Toyota Motor, which pioneered hybrid technology with its Prius in the late 1990s, credited hybrid sales for its strong U.S. sales performance this year. Through the first half of this year, sales of “electrified” vehicles – mostly hybrids, along with EVs – accounted for more than half of Toyota’s sales for the first time.

Industrywide, there has been a proliferation of hybrid entries into the popular compact SUV category, including Toyota’s RAV4 and Honda’s CR-V. GM offers gas-only versions of compact SUVs, including the Chevrolet Trax and Buick Envista. Nissan is fast-tracking a new hybrid Rogue compact SUV by several months with a planned rollout this autumn “in response to growing consumer demand for hybrid SUVs,” a spokesperson said.

“Everybody’s coming up with a hybrid in that space,” said Sridi Rajagopalan, vice president of customer success for OEM solutions at JD Power. “This is becoming a little bit more than just a phase or a fad.”

EVs for long haul

GM’s U.S. market share dropped to 16.8% in the first half of the year, from 17.6% a year prior, while hybrid leaders Toyota and Honda gained.

Automotive analyst John Murphy of Murphy Automotive Partners expects hybrid sales to hit 34% of U.S. sales in 2031. Still, he said it makes sense for GM to emphasise its highly profitable gas-only trucks and SUVs, while its EV lineup could position the company well if regulations tighten in coming years. GM’s strategy “is not as clear a major mistake as I think some people believe,” Murphy said.

Revamp of Japan’s Toyota indicates a larger industry shake-up in China

GAC to buy part of FAW Toyota’s stake, state media reports; deal comes as Toyota streamlines its China operation as sales under pressure; China’s overcrowded auto industry to accelerate consolidation

NEWS ANALYSIS

Reuters
BEIJING/SHANGHAI

A potential tie-up between Toyota’s two main Chinese partners could be a sign the long-standing foreign joint-venture model in China is entering a new phase as a shrinking market and brutal competition force automakers to become more efficient.

Guangzhou Automobile Group (GAC) said it planned to acquire a part of FAW Group’s stake in an unnamed auto JV with an overseas-listed company.

Chinese state media reported the venture was FAW Toyota, potentially paving the way for closer integration of Toyota’s two China businesses.

GAC and FAW did not respond to requests for comment. Toyota declined comment.

China, the world’s largest auto market, is on the cusp of a shakeout after years of rapid expansion left it with vast overcapacity and more than 100 competing car brands.

The proposed deal may foreshadow broader industry consolidation as overcapacity has undermined the economics of parallel networks, analysts said.

The auto industry has “long been suffering from involution, or loss-leading



Coming together: People visit the booth of carmaker GAC Group at Beijing auto expo. REUTERS

competition,” S&P Global Ratings said in a note on Tuesday, warning that weak demand, overcapacity and the rapid EV shift are testing state-owned automakers and foreign JVs. “We anticipate a broader wave of industry restructuring over the next two to three years,” S&P said.

Building scale

For decades, Toyota expanded in China through separate partnerships with FAW in the north and GAC in the south, a strategy that helped it build scale in a fast-growing market. But as growth has slowed, competition intensified and the shift to electric vehicles squeezed profits, the rationale for maintaining parallel operations has

weakened.

Bill Russo, founder of Shanghai-based consultancy Automobility, said there was a “sound industrial logic” to the move because Toyota could make its sales and distribution more efficient and lower overlapping investment.

But he cautioned that greater efficiency alone would not solve the chal-

lenges facing foreign auto makers in China.

Loss of relevance

“The more fundamental issue is the loss of relevance many global automakers face in consumer-facing technology,” Russo said, adding consolidation on its own would not restore the relevance of Toyota’s products.

“You can become more efficient at building a car that consumers increasingly overlook,” he said.

JVs under pressure

Foreign automakers that once dominated China’s auto market have steadily lost ground to local rivals over the past five years. BYD, Geely and Chery have gained greater market

Too much, too soon: reforms can come at a cost

OPINION

Arun Maira

India has moved too far from the original social objectives of economic development—employment, public investment, capability-building and economic security

A common refrain in India’s economic reforms establishment is that the 1991 reforms have not been implemented fully. These economists suggest that the government should take advantage of the economic crisis, as it had in 1991 when the management of the Indian economy was ‘liberalised’ under pressure from the Washington establishment. The government should push through with unfinished reforms.

A fundamental thrust of Washington Consensus’ economics was the privatisation of the economy, including public services. U.S. President Ronald Reagan, who was greatly influenced by Nobel laureate economist Milton Friedman (who said that ‘the business of business must be only business’), had declared that “government is not the solution: it is the problem”. In 2013, a popular writer on the Indian economy advocated faster privatisation of India’s education and health systems. He said India works at night when the government is asleep.

I was invited by Dr. Manmohan Singh, the architect of India’s liberal market reforms in 1991, to join India’s Planning Commission in July 2009, when he commenced his second term as India’s Prime Minister. I am not an economist, and I did not think I was qualified to serve in India’s apex planning institution. Dr.



For human touch: An aerial view of Banerghatta road and metro line in Bengaluru. GETTY IMAGES

Singh surprised me by saying he wanted me in the Commission not because I was not an economist but because I was a ‘systems thinker’. He said the 1991 reforms had not served Indian citizens well. The GDP was growing fast. Our policy makers had declared that India was the ‘fastest growing free market democracy’, in those heady ‘India Shining’ days.

The caveats of ‘free market’ and ‘democracy’ had to be added because it was embarrassing to admit that China’s economy had grown five times larger, and Chinese per capita incomes had increased eight times faster than India’s, though countries were at comparable levels at the end of the 1980s. Moreover, Chinese manufacturing industries, including high tech manufacturing, had dwarfed Indian industry. China had become the factory of the world by 2009, and Indian manufacturers were importing their components and machinery from China, enabled by the ease of imports that liberal

import policies had encouraged from 1991, along with the dismantling of India’s industrial policies.

Privatisation of services

Infrastructure and public services are crumbling in Indian cities, including Bengaluru, Gurugram, and Pune, hubs for high-tech ventures and expensive, private real estate.

Modern private hospitals, which attract medical tourists from many countries, are unaffordable for India’s common citizens. India’s education system, from primary schools to universities, has been extensively privatised, but good quality education is unaffordable for poor citizens.

On my first day in the Planning Commission in July 2009, my first visitor was a senior adviser in the Commission. He brought two assistants who placed a stack of books on my table. He said I should read them because they would provide me all I needed to know about implementation of reforms of the In-

dian economy. They were manuals of SOPs on how to implement PPPs (public private partnerships) in various sectors: road and transport infrastructure; power generation and distribution; urban water and electricity services; education and health, etc. All manuals had been prepared by legal experts so there would be no need for central ministries or state governments to consult further, he assured me. They could get on with speedy implementation of projects in partnerships with private companies who would bring expertise and invest in the ventures for profit. The government would provide them with land, permissions to use environmental resources and financial incentives to cover their risks.

Gujarat model

A ‘Gujarat model’ of development for India was advocated by economists Jagdish Bhagwati and Arvind Panagariya. Panagariya was appointed the first vice-chairman of the NITI

Aayog, with which Mr. Modi replaced the Planning Commission. They publicly derided Amartya Sen and Jene Dreze for suggesting that human development should precede economic growth, as in China. That was ‘socialism’, which had become a bad word from 1991, wherever mainly U.S.-led ideas of free markets and ‘minimum government’ economics had spread.

Human development indicators (HDI), which reflect the foundations of an economy, have remained very low in India, well behind China’s. Even much poorer Bangladesh has caught up with India in global HDI rankings, after India’s economic policies veered away from ‘socialism’ in 1991. A ‘million mutinies’ of students, workers, and farmers have risen against the system.

India’s GDP may be growing nicely, provided the government’s quarter to quarter statistics can be relied upon (about which there is doubt now amongst economists on all sides of the political spectrum). India’s stock market is doing well, even though it swings up and down nervously every day. India’s balance of payments is healthy, unlike 1991, propped by inflows of remittances by Indians working abroad and short-term financial investors. However, the pattern of economic growth is neither producing welfare, nor providing good jobs for India’s 600 million strong youth below the age of 25. The economy’s demographic dividend is slipping away.

India’s economic policies need some fundamental reforms. Here are nine recommendations.

1. Strengthen public sector in education and healthcare; reverse their

excessive privatisation

2. Put more equity into public welfare schemes instead of improving only their efficiency

3. Raise humanisation of the economy rather than its financialisation

4. Rather than more centralisation and digitisation, put more human agency on the ground and more substance into public services

5. Devolve power to local rural and urban communities for improving their local systems instead of the State delivering benefits directly to individual beneficiaries

6. Increase the ‘communitisation’, rather than ‘corporatisation’ of social enterprises

7. Put the voices and needs, of common citizens at the centre of public-private partnerships between governments and private sector companies. Change the formats of PPPs, i.e. public (government) and private partnerships, into ‘PPPPs’—people, public (government) and private partnerships

8. Measure the performance of public sector enterprises by the welfare they create for citizens, especially the neediest rather than financial returns they produce for investors. By this measure, the State Bank of India and the Life Insurance Corporation will beat even the best private sector banks who are measured only by the financial returns they provide in stock markets

9. Promote more technological depth in Indian-owned enterprises

Shakespeare said, “A rose by any other name will smell as sweet”. If this is socialism, so be it.

(The writer is author of Reimagining India’s Economy: The Road to a More Equitable Society)



A file photo of firefighters extinguishing a fire in Tambang, Kampar, in the Riau province of Indonesia in August. AFP

Sumatran elephant habitats face threat as wildfires spread

Agence France-Presse
JAKARTA

Critically endangered Sumatran elephants are being pushed closer to the brink as wildfires raze vast swathes of their habitat on the western island of Sumatra, Indonesian conservation group Geopix told AFP on Wednesday.

Indonesia has for weeks been battling fires in parts of Borneo and Sumatra that have blanketed the country in suffocating haze.

Geopix said in a report published on Tuesday that more than 4,500 hotspots had been detected in 21 Sumatran elephant habitats between June and early September, threatening one of the world's rarest elephant species.

The World Wildlife Fund estimates that only 2,400 to 2,800 Sumatran elephants remain in the wild.

More than 5,60,000 hectares burned during the same period, Geopix said in its report.

Hotspots within elephant habitats jumped to over 2,800 in the first week of September, more than double the roughly 1,300 recorded in August, the NGO said.

Geopix senior wildlife campaigner Annisa Rahmawati described the impact of the fires on Sumatran elephant habitats this year as "brutal".

"Ecologically, fires caused habitat loss, degradation and fragmentation, reducing food and water sources as well as changing the elephants' movement patterns," she said.

Ms. Annisa said exposure to toxic smoke from the fires could increase physiological stress among the animals.

She warned that shortages in food and water supplies could further dampen the elephants' ability to survive in the wild.

Reuters
MOSCOW

As a digital billboard behind her displays an advert urging Russians to sign up to fight in Ukraine, Polina Lermant tries to hand out flyers to passers-by urging them to "vote for peace" in a parliamentary election starting on Friday.

It's a risky enterprise.

Ms. Lermant, 24, a candidate in Moscow for Russia's liberal Yabloko party, the only registered political force inside Russia to oppose the war in Ukraine, said she feared the authorities might accuse her of wrongdoing and jail her, a fate some of her party colleagues have suffered.

"I'm really afraid. My parents and my husband are really worried about me. I am afraid that the repression will start," Ms. Lermant told Reuters in an interview as she campaigned.

Lev Shlosberg, a senior party colleague, was jailed for 11 years for comments about the war last month, and Yabloko's deputy leader, Maxim Kruglov, was jailed for seven years on similar charges in June.

Recalling how her grandfather was exiled to the Ural Mountains from Moscow in the Soviet era after being convicted of discrediting the Red Army, a charge now levelled against war critics over the modern Russian military,

she said fear had returned to society.

"It's really terrifying that 90 years later people in Russia are still afraid that they will be jailed or that something will be done to them," she said, referring to the increasingly narrow space for public dissent.

The Kremlin says war-time censorship and national unity are vital because of what it says are increasingly dangerous efforts by Ukraine's intelligence services and other enemies to stir unrest inside Russia.

Outcome not in doubt

Ms. Lermant is one of around a dozen candidates in Moscow from Yabloko running in the three-day election to the 450-seat lower house of parliament, the State Duma, which has a track record of faithfully approving the Kremlin's initiatives.

Yabloko wants Russia to agree to a ceasefire in Ukraine. The Kremlin has ruled this out, saying it wants an overall deal that meets its own conditions.

The parliamentary election is the first since President Vladimir Putin sent troops into Ukraine in 2022 and will be used by authorities to gauge the depth of society's war weariness when the economy is under strain – with fuel shortages caused by Ukrainian drone strikes, high interest rates, a labour crunch and Western sanctions.



Fighting for peace: Polina Lermant, 24, stands near a screen displaying a patriotic military illustration, amid Russia's war against Ukraine, as she hands out flyers to passers-by on a street in Moscow. REUTERS

For the Kremlin, it is also an exercise that it traditionally uses to project stability.

An advert being run on state TV urging people to vote shows Russian military commanders down the ages before cutting to soldiers holding up the national flag after winning a battle in Ukraine with the slogan: "Their voice is the voice of victory. Your vote is the strength of Russia!"

Western political analysts say the Kremlin is likely to tout the election's outcome – which in Russia's tightly controlled system is not in real doubt – as a fresh endorsement of Mr. Putin and his actions towards Ukraine.

The governing United Russia party (UR), which backs Mr. Putin, is expected to comfortably retain its

dominance.

Four other parties in parliament, which all broadly vote in the same way as UR on major issues – the Communists, the nationalist LDPR, Just Russia and the New People party – are expected to win reelection too.

Battered by arrests and jailings, Yabloko, whose participation gives it a platform for its anti-war views, is unlikely to win any national seats.

Stone in Kremlin's shoe

Once a leading liberal force in post-Soviet Russia, Yabloko holds only a handful of seats in regional parliaments and none in the national parliament although, unlike self-exiled opposition figures, it has for years worked within the system.

Most Yabloko candidates were barred from contesting the election after the Supreme Court ruled on August 10 that they had broken electoral rules, a ruling Ms. Lermant said was prompted by official fears that Yabloko would make it into parliament and raise awkward questions about subjects including the war.

Discrediting the army or spreading what authorities regard as fake news are punishable with long jail terms.

In many regions, filming and posting online the aftermath of Ukrainian drone strikes is also a criminal offence.

Ms. Lermant was initially one of 16 Yabloko candidates left in the race in Moscow because they were contesting single-mandate

constituencies rather than competing on a party-list basis. More of her fellow candidates have since been disqualified.

Despite her concerns, Ms. Lermant said she felt strongly she was doing the right thing.

"It's really important for us to tell people that there is the chance right now to vote for peace, to express their political position, and to say that we choose peace and a free life without fear," she said.

Support for peace talks

Ms. Lermant said she was encouraged by polling showing public support for peace negotiations had risen this year. This, she said, showed people were increasingly open to Yabloko's ideas.

Polling from the Levada Center – which the authorities have designated a foreign agent – put public support for peace talks above 60%.

Ms. Lermant also referenced data from a government pollster showing support for Yabloko had been rising before most of its candidates were barred from contesting the election.

Regular pre-election polling by the main government-aligned pollsters no longer includes Yabloko, making it hard to gauge its popularity. The same pollsters have usually put its support in low single digits.

Rights abuses persist in Venezuela despite Maduro's ouster: UN report

Reuters
GENEVA

A UN-mandated probe said on Wednesday that Venezuela's apparatus of repression remains largely intact despite a reduction in some abuses following President Nicolas Maduro's removal from power earlier this year.

The U.S., which abducted Mr. Maduro, has locked him up to face trial on drug-trafficking charges, but left his Socialist Party government largely intact, to the disappointment of Venezuela's opposition which says it was robbed of a 2024 vote and should be in power.

In a report to the UN Human Rights Council, the independent fact-finding mission said Mr. Maduro's capture in January led to a fall in long-term politically motivated detentions and related abuses, but did not amount to a fundamental break with years of repression.



A file photo of opposition supporters staging a protest demanding a presidential election in Caracas on September 3. REUTERS

dependent fact-finding mission said Mr. Maduro's capture in January led to a fall in long-term politically motivated detentions and related abuses, but did not amount to a fundamental break with years of repression.

"The measures of political liberalization adopted since that date remain partial, conditional and reversible at best," the mission said.

Venezuela's mission to the UN in Geneva did not immediately respond to a

request for comment.

The report, covering the period from September last year to July, described the U.S. intervention as a breach of international law.

The independent UN experts said senior officials linked to past repression remained in key positions and security agencies, intelligence services and laws used to restrict dissent had not undergone meaningful reform.

The mission said hundreds of people, including real or perceived opponents of the government, remained arbitrarily detained for political reasons and continued to face harsh prison conditions, torture and ill-treatment.

Good business



Net profit: A fisherman carries his catch, including hammerhead sharks, at the Sirah fish market in Aden, Yemen, on Tuesday. AP

OpenAI's rogue agents probed Hugging Face two months before major hack

Reuters
WASHINGTON

Rogue AI agents from OpenAI hijacked Hugging Face user accounts and probed the site itself for vulnerabilities as early as May, nearly two months before the July breach of the open-source repository drew global attention, according to researchers who reviewed the activity.

The newly uncovered malicious activity showed that the rogue agents' efforts to find a way into Hugging Face began earlier than publicly known.

OpenAI had previously disclosed one aspect of the malicious activity – the theft of a Hugging Face user's digital credential to access a biology-related file – in its public incident report last month, but researchers

told Reuters the probing activity against Hugging Face appeared to go beyond what was described in the report.

The activity was discovered by independent researcher Jonas Wiedermann-Moeller last week, he told Reuters. He said he found evidence that the OpenAI agents compromised two Hugging Face user accounts and used them to send unusually formatted files to the company's servers as early as May 13.

He and other researchers who reviewed the evidence said the behavior resembled an attempt to map or test parts of Hugging Face's network for ways to infiltrate, although they stressed there was no evidence the effort resulted in an actual breach.



Researcher Jonas Wiedermann-Moeller told Reuters that he discovered the activity last week. REUTERS

OpenAI spokesperson Drew Pusateri said the company had disclosed the May 13 event, privately notified Hugging Face about the activity flagged by Mr. Wiedermann-Moeller and was "committed to transparency about these issues and to sharing what

we learn as our review continues."

Hugging Face, recently acquired by chipmaker Nvidia, did not respond to requests for comment.

Mr. Wiedermann-Moeller, a 27-year-old who lives in Bielefeld, Germany, said OpenAI's failure to detect

the May 13 probing at the time was a missed opportunity to prevent the subsequent hacking campaign, which has triggered a global reckoning over the power of artificial intelligence.

"Imagine if they caught this behavior in May," he

said in an interview. "It could've prevented the later incident, which was way bigger."

OpenAI has previously said that, with the benefit of hindsight, "some early signals" from its AI agents should have triggered an earlier response.

'Clear warning sign'

Two outside experts who reviewed Mr. Wiedermann-Moeller's findings said they were consistent with activity previously linked to OpenAI's agents.

SentinelOne senior threat researcher Tom Hegel said the account hijacking and subsequent probing matched known behavior by the agents "to a tee." Sydney Von Arx of the Nightingale Collective, an AI safety group, agreed with the attribution.

Ms. Von Arx said the hacking amounted to a "clear warning sign" that could have helped prevent the breach in July.

OpenAI has faced increasing scrutiny since the company disclosed on July 21 that rogue AI agents bypassed internal controls, reached the open internet and coordinated actions that OpenAI described as "an unprecedented cyber incident."

Since then, outside researchers have identified additional incidents alleged to involve OpenAI-linked agents, including activity affecting a dormant German wiki site and the RubyGems software package repository.

OpenAI has acknowledged some of those incidents only after they were publicly reported by third

parties. Two people familiar with the matter said that, in the case of RubyGems, OpenAI employees only realised its AI was responsible for the malicious activity after the Nightingale Collective found it.

The additional discoveries have fueled questions among lawmakers and AI safety advocates about whether the full scope of the incidents has been identified.

Some of America's top AI executives have since called for a slowdown of AI development, citing, among other things, the threat of devastating cyber attacks by out-of-control agents. Mr. Wiedermann-Moeller said the latest findings reinforced calls for a temporary slowdown in the development of advanced AI systems.

GETTING A LOOK-IN
Varun ruled out of Asian Games, Vipraj named as replacement



FILE PHOTO

Vipraj Nigam will replace Varun Chakaravarthy in India's Asian Games squad after the latter was ruled out of the continental event with a side strain. **The squad:** Shreyas (Capt.), Tilak (Vice-capt.), Abhishek, Samson (wk), Kishan (wk), Dube, Axar, Washington, Bishnoi, Bumrah, Arshdeep, Sooryavanshi, Yash Thakur, and Vipraj.

GOLD DUST
He bowls the same way whenever you bowl him: Aakash on Bumrah



SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

Former India cricketer Aakash Chopra praised the team's bowling unit for maintaining control in the second T20I against Afghanistan. Hailing Jasprit Bumrah's economical spell, he said, "Bumrah conceded 25 runs in four overs and picked up a wicket. He is gold. He bowls the same way whenever you bowl him."

LEAD CHARACTER
Brook's unbeaten hundred sets up England's mammoth victory



REUTERS

England captain Harry Brook smashed 10 fours and six sixes in an unbeaten 114 off just 49 balls to set up a 119-run win over Sri Lanka in the first of three T20Is at Southampton on Tuesday. **The scores:** England 254/4 in 20 overs (Brook 114 n.o., Buttler 80) bt Sri Lanka 135 in 19 overs (Wellalage 33, Baker 3/12). **Toss:** SL. **PoM:** Brook.

PROLIFIC
Buttler overtakes Rohit to become second-highest T20I run-scorer



REUTERS

England's Jos Buttler surpassed Rohit Sharma to become the second-highest run-scorer in T20Is. Buttler achieved the feat with his 44-ball 80 during England's first T20I against Sri Lanka. Buttler has 4,292 runs in 161 T20Is, moving past Rohit (4,231 in 159). Pakistan's Babar Azam leads the charts (4,596 in 145).

India aims for a series sweep, Afghans hope to script a win

Samson's half-century and Nitish's three-wicket haul in the second T20I a welcome sign for Shreyas & Co.; after two ducks, opener Gurbaz will be keen to get going

CRICKET

Vivek Krishnan
NEW DELHI

Business as usual. That is how India's T20I series win over Afghanistan has seemed, having barely dropped a bead of sweat whilst registering consecutive seven-wicket wins at the Arun Jaitley Stadium in the national capital. The tour of the United Kingdom in June-July, where India went without a victory in six completed T20Is against Ireland and England, may have thrown a spanner in the works in Shreyas Iyer's first assignment as captain. But back in familiar territory, albeit Afghanistan is the official host for the ongoing series, India has reiterated its near-impregnability.

Numbers bear testimony. Since July 2024, the Men in Blue have won 23 out of 27 T20Is in India. This splendid run includes the T20 World Cup in February and March, which they lifted for the second time in succession. They have prevailed in every bilateral assignment in India in this phase.

If the possibility of Afghanistan causing an upset was faint before the series, the last vestiges of hope vanished into thin air once India won the toss and opted to chase under lights in both fixtures.



Dominant: An all-round show by India has proved too much for Afghanistan. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

Considering the ease with which Shreyas & Co. have knocked off targets of 157 and 160, Afghanistan's spin department, known to be its strong suit, has had to face some of the heat. But the Rashid Khan-led attack hasn't been aided one bit by the below-par returns of the batters. "The par total on that wicket would be about 200. That would have given us something realistic to bowl at. We didn't set a target that could have been defended," Afghanistan coach Richard Pybus rued after the loss in the second T20I on Tuesday. If Ibrahim Zadran's men are to salvage a win in Thursday's dead rubber, one among the top four

will have to bat deep. Rahmanullah Gurbaz, who has been dismissed on nought both times, will hope to be that batter. "Gurbaz is usually our most explosive player in the top-order. I know he's really disappointed. He loves the big occasions. I'm sure he'll have something special for us in the third game," said Pybus. From India's perspective, it couldn't have asked for a better tune-up to the Asian Games in Japan. All its parts are in order, with Sanju Samson's half-century and Nitish Kumar's three-wicket haul in the second T20I arousing further confidence within the camp. Before the players board

the flight to eastern Asia to defend their gold medal, rest assured that a series whitewash will be on their radar. **The teams (from): Afghanistan:** Ibrahim Zadran (Capt.), Darwish Rasooli, Noor ul Rahman (wk), Rahmanullah Gurbaz (wk), Sediqullah Atal, Azmatullah Omarzai, Gulbadin Naib, Mohammad Nabi, Nangeyalia Kharote, Rashid Khan, Abdullah Ahmadzai, Fazalhaq Farooqi, Mujeeb Ur Rahman, Naveen-ul-Haq, and Noor Ahmad. **India:** Shreyas Iyer (Capt.), Tilak Varma, Abhishek Sharma, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, Sanju Samson (wk), Ishan Kishan (wk), Shivam Dube, Nitish Kumar, Axar Patel, Washington Sundar, Ravi Bishnoi, Jasprit Bumrah, Arshdeep Singh, and Yash Thakur. *Match starts at 7.30 p.m.*



Topsy-turvy ride: Samson was back to wielding his willow like a cutlass with a blistering 57 off 22 balls. SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

I try to shut out the noise, says Samson

Vivek Krishnan
NEW DELHI

The past few months have proved to be a microcosm of Sanju Samson's chequered international career. If his form at the business end of this year's T20 World Cup – he won the Player-of-the-Tournament award with 321 runs in five innings – was a dazzling high, the tour of the United Kingdom just three months later was a debilitating low. After just two games against Ireland and one against England, which yielded returns of 5, 0 and 1, he made way for teen prodigy Vaibhav Sooryavanshi. While Samson came back for the fifth and final T20I against the Englishmen, he had already been omitted for the subsequent tour of Zimbabwe. Samson's topsy-turvy ride hasn't halted. At the Arun Jaitley Stadium on Tuesday, the 31-year-old from Kerala was back to wielding his willow like a cutlass, scything the Afghanistan attack for a blistering 57 off 22 balls in a

chase of 160. In the aftermath, Samson spoke with refreshing candour and endearing wit, and showed no resentment at recent developments. "After a few failures, you definitely go through a lot as an Indian cricketer. It is not easy to face failures. But that is where my experience comes in. I try to shut out the noise and still try to keep scoring at a high strike rate," the opener told reporters. At a time when social media is all-pervasive, how does he stay immune to the outside noise? "I try to switch off the wi-fi," he chuckled. "But sometimes the wi-fi switches on and the comments of some former players crop up. It is their choice to say what they want to say. I have become mature and experienced enough to handle that. It does affect you. We are not robots. But I try to be clear. If I was affected by the noise, I wouldn't be able to play the way I do. Before every attacking shot, I would be thinking 10 times."

Nabi, Naman get ODI call-ups for WI series

Sports Bureau
NEW DELHI

Auqib Nabi and Naman Dhir have earned maiden ODI call-ups for the home series against the West Indies beginning on September 27. With the three-match ODI series clashing with the Asian Games, the selectors have had to ensure there is no overlap between the two squads. All-rounder Nitish Kumar, who was originally part of the Asian Games contingent, has been pulled out of the multi-sport event and instead included in the ODI squad.

While there was speculation during the ODIs against England in July that Rohit Sharma may no longer be part of India's plans, the senior opener shrugged off the chatter by scoring a hundred in the final game at Lord's. Rohit, Virat Kohli and Ravindra Jadeja are all part of the ODI series against the men from the Caribbean, providing vast experience to the Shubman Gill-led squad. Hardik Pandya, who hasn't played since the IPL due to injury, will have to wait for his return. He is likely to feature for India-A in three One-Dayers against Australia-A in Puducherry from October 6 to 11. India will also be playing five T20Is against the West Indies. Jasprit Bumrah, who will spearhead the attack at the Asian Games, has been rested for these matches. The selectors also announced the Rest of India squad for the Irani Cup against Jammu & Kashmir,



Naman Dhir. FILE PHOTO

which will be played from October 1 to 5 at the Sher-i-Kashmir Stadium in Srinagar. Rishabh Pant, who has been omitted from the matches against WI, will lead the Rest of India squad.

India's ODI squad vs. WI: Shubman Gill (Capt.), K.L. Rahul (Vice-capt.), Rohit Sharma, Virat Kohli, Ruturaj Gaikwad, Dhruv Jurel (wk), Nitish Kumar, Ravindra Jadeja, Kuldeep Yadav, Prasidh Krishna, Gurnoor Brar, Mohammed Siraj, Auqib Nabi, Yashasvi Jaiswal, Naman Dhir. **The schedule:** Sept. 27 (Thiruvananthapuram), Sept. 30 (Guwahati) and Oct. 3 (New Chandigarh). **India's T20I squad vs. WI:** Shreyas Iyer (Capt.), Tilak Varma (Vice-capt.), Abhishek Sharma, Vaibhav Sooryavanshi, Ishan Kishan (wk), Sanju Samson (wk), Shivam Dube, Kuldeep Yadav, Axar Patel, Washington Sundar, Ravi Bishnoi, Nitish Kumar, Arshdeep Singh, Prince Yadav, Mayank Yadav. **The dates:** Oct. 6 (Lucknow), Oct. 9 (Ranchi), Oct. 11 (Indore), Oct. 14 (Hyderabad) and Oct. 17 (Bengaluru). **Rest of India squad for Irani Cup (Oct. 1 to 5 in Srinagar):** Rishabh Pant (Capt. & wk), Sarfaraz Khan (Vice-capt.), Sanat Sengwan, Shikhar Mahan, Sudip Gharami, Smaran Ravichandran, Manav Suthar, Saransh Jain, Akash Deep*, Mukesh Kumar, Mukesh Choudhary, Aryan Juyal (wk), Aryan Pandey, Anukul Roy, Ayush Doseja. * Subject to fitness.

WPL 2027
from Jan. 14 to Feb. 7

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The fifth edition of the Women's Premier League will be played from January 14 to February 7, 2027 while its auction will be held on October 28 this year in Kochi, the BCCI announced on Wednesday. The BCCI however did not disclose the host cities for the WPL. "As the biggest T20 league in women's cricket, the TATA WPL has established itself as a significant platform for the growth of the sport, bringing together leading players from India and around the world while creating opportunities for emerging talent to perform at the highest level," said the BCCI. The Player Retention deadline is set for September 28. "The five franchises will have the opportunity to retain players from their existing squads as they begin putting their combinations in place," the BCCI added.

India beats Thailand but Arjun loses; women have it easy

CHESS OLYMPIAD

Sports Bureau

It wasn't quite the perfect start for India at the Chess Olympiad in Samarkand on Wednesday. The women won 4-0 against Dominican Republic alright, but the men's team, though expectedly victorious against Thailand, suffered a shock loss on the top board. Arjun Erigaisi was humbled by Prin Laohawirapap, who is rated 396 Elo points below him. That meant India could win only 3-1. Arjun, with white pieces, was struggling against the clock, and after he took his queen to the wrong square on the 50th move and was doomed. He resigned just four moves later. There were wins, however, for Nihal Sarin, D. Gukesh and Vidit Gujrathi. R. Praggnanandhaa, India's top-board player, was benched for the match.



Smooth start: The women's team of Humpy, Vaishali, Vantika and Savitha Shri broke no sweat in scoring victories. FIDE

In the women's match against Dominican Republic, Koneru Humpy, R. Vaishali, Vantika Agrawal and B. Savitha Shri won their games. India is the defending champion in both the open and women's sections. The opening day also saw Pakistan making a political move. It refused to play against Israel and gave a walkover (0-4). **Important results:** **Open: India bt Thailand 3-1** (Arjun Erigaisi lost to Prin Laohawirapap; Nihal Sarin bt Thanadon Kulpruethanon; D. Gukesh bt Faris Alriyami; Vidit

Gujrathi bt Tupfah Khumnarokaew). **USA bt Iraq 3.5-0.5;** Uzbekistan bt Jamaica 4-0; China bt Uganda 4-0; Germany bt Faroe Islands 4-0; Azerbaijan bt Morocco 4-0; Hungary bt Malta 2.5-1.5; France bt Tunisia 4-0. **Women: India bt Dominican Republic 4-0** (Koneru Humpy bt Franchesca Ramirez Luzon; R. Vaishali bt Miguelina De La Rosa Martinez; Vantika Agrawal bt Mary Loly Gonzalez Peguero; B. Savitha Shri bt Karla Mya Nunez Diaz). **Uzbekistan bt Uganda 4-0;** Georgia bt Tunisia 4-0; Kazakhstan bt Botswana 4-0; China bt Zambia 4-0; Ukraine bt Iraq 4-0; Azerbaijan bt Guatemala 4-0; France bt Morocco 4-0; Poland bt Zimbabwe 4-0.

An even contest in the offing on the hard-courts of Seoul

DAVIS CUP

N. Sudarshan

India is not an elite tennis nation. Yet, it is among the elite 15 still remaining in this year's Davis Cup, a position it last attained in 2011 as part of the 16-team World Group in the erstwhile Cup format. Starting Friday, India will attempt to soar higher when it takes on South Korea in round two of the Davis Cup Qualifiers. At stake in Seoul is a place in the Finals, an ultra-elite grouping of eight nations including defending champion Italy. "It's a mix of pressure and motivation," India No. 1 Sumit Nagal told *The Hindu* from Seoul. "There is always pressure when you play for the country. There is motivation as well because we have never been in this situation. We are going to put our hearts into it." Fine performances against higher-ranked European nations, like the 3-1



Much at stake: The Indian team will strive to make it to the ultra-elite group of eight nations. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

victory over Switzerland in September 2025 and the 3-2 success over Netherlands earlier in 2026, have been the catalysts. Luck has been a factor too. Switzerland and Netherlands didn't have all of their best players, and now South Korea is ranked just three places above (16 to India's 19). In fact, of the countries still in the tournament, which include heavyweights such as Spain,

France, the United States and Germany, the bottom three are South Korea, India and Ecuador (23). This makes the upcoming hard-court tie an even contest. In Soonwoo Kwon, Korea has a multiple-time Tour titlist and someone ranked World No. 52 in 2021. The 28-year-old is returning after 18 months of compulsory military service, and is back up to No. 157. Hyeon Chung, 30, has

had an injury-ravaged career, but was in the top-20 in 2018 and even beat Novak Djokovic at the Australian Open that year. Kwon and Chung fashioned the memorable 3-2 triumph over Argentina in February 2026. "They are good, and they have played the ATP-level for many years," said Nagal. "Kwon is a good baseliner and Chung has a lot of experience. It's going to be tough." India's trump card may again be the big-serving Dhakshinewar Suresh. The 26-year-old is not yet a regular on the Tour, but has a 4-0 Davis Cup record and won both his singles and doubles rubbers against Netherlands. "The courts are pretty slow but I still have to use my weapons and stay more patient than rushing through the points," opined Dhakshinewar. "But you have to adapt, like playing on the Tour, because conditions will be different every week."

INBRIEF



Espi saves Real's blushes with late winner at Elche

Real Madrid substitute Carlos Espi snatched his team a last-gasp 3-2 win at Elche on Tuesday in LaLiga.

The results: Rayo Vallecano 2 (Garcia 3, Pedrosa 26) bt Espanyol 1 (Fernandez 54); Alaves 0 lost to Valencia 1 (Rioja 78); Elche 2 (Osorio 71, Nino 83) lost to Real Madrid 3 (Dituro 25-og, Mbappe 33, Espi 90+1).

ACT: Pakistan requests AHF to shift its matches from India

Pakistan on Wednesday asked the Asian Hockey Federation to shift its Asian Champions Trophy matches to a neutral venue, citing a “sensitive bilateral situation” with host India. The Pakistan Hockey Federation (PHF) said it wanted a neutral venue to ensure the country’s uninterrupted and full participation in the men’s Asian Champions Trophy. The ACT will be held in Mohali and Jalandhar from October 27 to November 5.

IPL 2027 auction to be held in India, says Dhumal

The IPL players’ auction for the 2027 season is set to be held in India, with league chairman Arun Dhumal saying that he is keen to bring the event back home after holding it overseas for the past three years. “Every year we try for this to happen in India, but we don’t get the venue given the heavy marriage season. Given that it would be a smaller auction, hopefully we will get the venue,” Dhumal, who is set to be re-elected as IPL chairman during the BCCI AGM on September 18, said. The host city will be decided based on the availability of BCCI’s preferred venue. At a recent Governing Council meeting, the contentious Impact Player concept was also discussed after the BCCI asked the teams for fresh feedback on the rule that is supposed to be in place till 2027. “The matter is under discussion. Will take a feedback from all the stakeholders and then take a call on this,” Dhumal added.



Argentina calls up Messi for farewell game against Benin

Lionel Messi was, on Tuesday, named in Argentina’s squad for a friendly against Benin on October 6, a match that will serve as his farewell appearance after announcing his international retirement last month.

James Rodriguez retires from Colombian national team

Colombian footballer James Rodriguez, one of the best players in the country’s history, on Tuesday announced his retirement from the national team after 15 years and three World Cups. “I’m leaving with serenity because I know I gave absolutely everything,” the 35-year-old captain said in a social media video, his eyes welling with tears.

NADA provisionally suspends eight Indian athletes

The National Anti-Doping Agency (NADA) has provisionally suspended eight athletes for different anti-doping violations. Ashu and Kaushal Kumar (all mephentermine), Juihar Singh (EPO), para-athlete Bhagat Singh (mephentermine, morphine), Baljit Kaur (metenolone, oxandrolone), Nabeel Sahi (mephentermine, 19-norandrosterone), Ravi (mephentermine, meldonium, 19-norandrosterone) and National inter-State bronze medalist in 200m Prakruthi Rupa Rao (stanazolol, drostanolone) have been provisionally suspended for testing positive for banned substances. Coach Rakesh Kumar has been suspended for life by a NADA disciplinary panel. Sanjana Singh (five years), Sachin Poswal (four years), Seema Punia (two years), Nitesh Poonia (two years), Anjali Kumari (six years) and Shashikesh Kumar (three years) have also got suspensions. International archer Sukhmuni Babrekar has been suspended for 18 months.

Greater emphasis on cultural sensitivity as Indian athletes arrive in Japan

The host nation is very strict in terms of how you behave, how you dress and how you manage your waste: Deputy chef de mission Sharath Kamal

ASIAN GAMES

Jonathan Selvaraj
NEW DELHI

Don’t litter. Carry your trash until you find a bin. Cover visible tattoos. Queue properly. Use earphones, avoid loud music in public, and do not hug or touch strangers. As India’s athletes arrive in Nagoya for the Asian Games, they have been briefed on Japanese etiquette. “You are not just travelling to Japan as an athlete; you are representing India. Respect the rules, respect the people, respect the culture,” says a Sports Authority of India video shared with participants. Deputy chef de mission and table tennis great



New digs: A view of the container-based housing units for athletes in Nagoya. REUTERS

Achanta Sharath Kamal says greater emphasis has been placed on cultural sensitivity this time. “Japan is very, very

strict in terms of how you behave, how you dress and how you manage your waste. There are very few dustbins, but you can’t lit-

ter anywhere. You need to carry the trash back to where the dustbin is,” Sharath told *Sportstar*. Athletes have also been

sensitised about sexual harassment and abuse. “There’s no excuse for it. You can’t touch anybody for any reason,” he said. Preparation has extended to accommodation. Some athletes will stay in shipping containers and cruise ships, with prototypes set up at national training centres in Bengaluru, Patiala and elsewhere so athletes could experience the limited space beforehand. Sharath, who has travelled three times to Nagoya in the build-up, says conditions have changed sharply since his first visit last year. “Last year it was 40 degrees and clear skies. This year there have been typhoons... there was flooding a few days back.” The Games will also be logistically challenging.

Unlike Hangzhou, where events were largely centralised, Nagoya’s venues and accommodation are spread across a wide area. Hockey, for instance, will be based near its venue, around 90 minutes from the repurposed Games village. India has consequently decentralised medical support, with doctors and physiotherapists across locations. It has also pushed for consistent food options, including halal meals and comfort food such as plain *daal*, and mapped Indian restaurants near athletes’ hotels. The organisers initially planned four athletes per 12-by-18-foot container but reduced that to two after objections from India and other countries. Boxing weigh-ins have also been moved to the team hotel.

Vijender expects India to win five or six medals at Asian Games

BOXING

Y.B. Sarangi

World and Olympic medalist Vijender Singh has advised the Asian Games-bound Indian boxers to cut out all distractions, including mobile phones, and focus on winning medals. “I told them, don’t distract your mind with that phone or media or anything. Just focus. It’s a war. You should win the war. After that, do whatever you want to do,” said Vijender, a 2008 Olympic bronze medalist in middleweight, in a virtual interaction. He expected Indian boxers to win five to six medals.

“Sakshi (Choudhary, 51kg) is hard-working. Preeti Pawar (54kg) is doing well. Priya Ghanghas (60kg) will also perform well. And Lovlina (Borgohain, 75kg). The girls are more hungry for medals. Among boys, Sachin (Siwach, 60kg) is good. And (Narendra) Berwal (+90kg). He got an Asian Games medal and Arjuna Award. He must be confident. “But I feel the girls will perform better. Most of them are from Haryana. In the news, people say Haryanvi people don’t like girls. But our girls (are) changing everything.”



Sakshi. FILE PHOTO

Vijender, who bagged a bronze and a gold in the 2006 and 2010 Asian Games respectively, shared how he made light of a dislocated left thumb to upset World champion Abbos Atoev in the Guangzhou Asiad final to secure gold. Harboursing a competitive mindset, Vijender asked the Indians to ignore the concerns emerging from Japan. “It doesn’t matter if the room is big or small. What matters is our performance. We aren’t going there to have fun. We are going there to fight. And we have to win that fight. “Countries like Kazakhstan, Uzbekistan, China and Japan are doing well. The Asian Games will be tough but our boxers are in good shape. I hope they will do well,” he said. (Watch Asian Games live and exclusive on Sony Sports Network and Sony LIV).

How coach Adhiban went from fast to feast

CHESS

P.K. Ajith Kumar

One of the most memorable moments of the Tech Mahindra Global Chess League, which concluded in Bengaluru on Sunday, came after the match between Ganges Grandmasters and Cheq Mumbai Masters, earlier. The Grandmasters won the match, the best player of which was Stavroula Tsolakidou. The Greek player, however, handed over the trophy to the Grandmasters’ coach, B. Adhiban, making his debut in such a role. She said he deserved it more. Adhiban graciously accepted the trophy from her on the stage. He revealed he had indeed helped Tso-



Good catch: Adhiban said he was glad the team got Aronian, in pic, and Nepomniachtchi as the two main players. P.K. AJITH KUMAR

lakidou with her preparation and suggested the openings for her various opponents. “She is an excellent student and has excellent memory,” Adhiban told *The Hindu*. “I was happy to work with her and see that we were getting the results right through the GCL.” Tsolakidou went on to win the Player-of-the-Tour-

nament award. She, in fact, was a revelation. “People, including some of our teammates did not expect her to do so well,” said Adhiban, who was part of the bronze-medal winning Indian teams at the Olympiad in 2014 and 2022. “Our other female player, Polina Shuvalova was also brilliant, but I wasn’t surprised by her, as

she is very good in these fast time controls.” He feels the Grandmasters team was just perfect, though there was uncertainty going into the auction. A new management had taken over, and he joined only shortly before the auction. “I was glad that we could get Levon Aronian and Ian Nepomniachtchi as our two main players,” said the Chennai-based Grandmaster. “Leinier Dominguez Perez and Leon Mendonca also delivered for us.” Adhiban contributed in another way. After the early disappointments, he decided to fast – skipping breakfast and lunch – and to have dinner only if his team won. The players weren’t aware of that. But, they played so well that Adhiban could have his dinner, after all.

‘The environment of a multi-sport event is something the team is looking forward to’

CRICKET

Press Trust of India
TOKYO

The Indian women’s cricket team head coach Amol Muzumdar said his players are eagerly looking forward to the unique atmosphere of the Asian Games after the defending

champion landed in Japan determined to extend its recent run of success. “The team is looking forward to the Asian Games and enjoying the environment of the multi-sport event,” Muzumdar said after arriving here with members of his support staff. A few members of the squad travelled with the

coaching staff, while the rest were scheduled to arrive later in the day, with pacer Kranti Gaud and spinner Shree Charani among those to land with the coaching staff. Muzumdar said the experience of living alongside athletes from different sports, sharing the Games Village and competing on a multi-sport stage is so-

omething he wants his players to embrace. “The environment of a multi-sport event is something the team is looking forward to. We want the players to enjoy that experience as well.” India begins its Asian Games campaign with a quarterfinal game against hosts Japan on September 18 at Nisshin.

Asiad boxing medallists will directly book berths in Worlds

Sports Bureau
KOLKATA

The Asian Games 2026 medallists will directly book their berths in next year’s World boxing championships, which will be the first qualifying event for the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics, the Boxing Federation of India (BFI) said on Wednesday. “We have tried to make the selection policy comprehensive and fair so that no good boxer is left out,” said a BFI official. “Asian Games medallists will be selected as the main entries in their respective weight categories. The gold medallists of the 10th National championships shall serve as reserve entries in those weight categories,” said the BFI circu-

lar. The 10th National championships will be held in Guwahati (women) and Patna (men) in December. For weight categories in which India does not win medals at the Asian Games and the LA 2028 weight categories that are not part of the Asiad (men’s 65kg and women’s 57kg and 70kg), the gold medallists of the above-mentioned Nationals will be selected as main entries. The Asian qualifier in China next year and two World qualifying tournaments in 2028 will also provide quota places for LA28. Indian boxers losing in the ‘quota bout round’ (the winner of which earns a quota place) at the World championships will get direct entry to the Asian

qualifiers. The remaining slots will be filled through a ranking selection trial among elite National campers after the boxers enter the National camp through dedicated pathways. A similar process will be followed for the two World qualifying tournaments, to be held in Italy and Hungary, in 2028. The National camp will start with medallists of the 10th National championships, Asian Games medallists and wild cards to be selected by the BFI selection committee. For non-Olympic weights, gold medallists of the Nationals will be the main entries for the World championships in Kazakhstan, while the silver medallists will be the reserves.

Millie, Mona, Avani win team gold at para shooting Worlds

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Millie Shah, Mona Agarwal and Avani Lekhara combined to win the R2 women’s 10m air rifle standing SH1 team gold aggregating 1878.6 at the Changwon 2026 WSPS para shooting World Championships in South Korea recently. Rakesh Nidagundi, Anandha Krishna and Swaroop Unhalkar claimed the R1 men’s 10m air rifle standing SH1 team silver with a combined total of 1856.3 across five series. Mona and Avani also won a silver and bronze respectively in the R2 women’s 10m air rifle standing SH1 event. In the R1 discipline,



On top: Mona, Avani and Millie after their title winning tilt. X@AVANILEKHARA

male athletes with lower or upper limb impairments independently support the full weight of their rifle from a standing or sitting position to hit a target 10 metres away.

The R2 women’s event features competitors with lower limb impairments who independently support the rifle while shooting from a standing or sitting position.

R. Kaushik

One of the hallmarks of a champion outfit is the propensity to eke out match-turning performances from different quarters and not depend on just one or two individuals to carry the day. India are nothing if not a champion outfit, their 20-over June misadventures in Ireland and England notwithstanding. There is a reason why they have won the last two T20 World Cups, there is a reason why they have been able to tide over potentially crippling loss of personnel through injuries and still put out formidable, fighting fit units.

India have numerous fallback options for almost every position when it comes to the T20 format, specifically. Especially from a batting standpoint, there is so much depth and quality and choices that it is inevitable that many who might have walked into any other side are not even on the fringes of consideration for selection. Why, India didn't think twice before giving Suryakumar Yadav the heave-ho immediately after the Mumbaikar masterminded a successful defence of the World Cup, and that too on home soil - neither feat accomplished previously. His middling to ordinary form overshadowed his leadership and man-management chops as preparations for the next World Cup began immediately after the trophy was lifted in Ahmedabad in March.

For the longest time, Suryakumar was ranked the No. 1 T20I batter globally and even though his form slumped dramatically in his last 15 months in charge, he still has plenty of cricket left in him. Yet, to sever ties ruthlessly pointed to prudence over sentiment, never mind if it wasn't a popular call or, to many, even an immediately warranted one.

While there are deserving and excellent alternatives for most roles within the Indian cricketing landscape, the one most coveted for obvious reasons is a fast-bowling all-rounder. So many countries take that spot for granted, almost. Even today, Australia have Mitchell Marsh (who doesn't bowl so much these days) and Marcus Stoinis, not to mention Cameron Green and Beau Webster. England have a long list, as do South Africa who, since their return from isolation, have thrown up numerous such luminaries. West Indies too can dip into that giving bag while New Zealand have a generous assortment to select from.

India, though, haven't always been blessed with an overflowing cup when it comes to this specific requirement. There have been all-rounders of various degrees of proficiency in the post-Kapil Dev era, with Irfan Pathan perhaps being the most successful of the lot. It was a given that Kapil was irreplaceable; the Haryana Hurricane was a generational genius and any quest to unearth a like-for-like substitute was always going to be an exercise in futility. As India meandered from one alternative to another, they stumbled upon Hardik Pandya, a natural athlete who could crank up the pace, who struck the ball a mile and who was an electric fielder.

Pandya slammed a century and snared a five-wicket in his brief Test career - 11 Tests in 13 months between July 2017 and August 2018 - but taking a cue from his complaining body, decided that the longer version was not his cup of tea. It wasn't that the spirit wasn't willing, but his body couldn't take the load of Test cricket. India would have loved for Pandya to keep continuing to play the five-day game but instead were happy to settle for his services in the two white-ball versions, though even there, he has been compelled to miss increasingly more matches in the last couple of years as he sidles towards his mid-30s.

The closest India now have to a Pandya sub is Nitish Kumar, himself no stranger to injuries though he is only 23 and has been an international for exactly as many months. Nitish's appearances for the country across the three formats has been restricted to a mere 22 games - 10 in Tests and six apiece in ODIs and T20Is, not so much because he has been considered superfluous to requirement as owing to the fact that he has often been unavailable for selection.

This ongoing Afghanistan series marks another comeback from the infirmary for the young man from the port city of Visakhapatnam. In June, he picked up a quadriceps injury that kept him away from the twin tours of Ireland and England, and the subsequent three-match sojourn in Zimbabwe. The quadriceps problem is the latest in an already long and burgeoning list of injuries - hernia (June 2024), side strain (January 2025), knee (July 2025), neck spasms (October 2025) and quadriceps (also October 2025).

Around all this, in his desire to become the 'best all-rounder' (his words), Nitish embarked on a mission to ramp up his pace, ahead of IPL 2026. After watching *Instagram* videos on biomechanics and fast bowling, he got in touch with protagonist Steffan Jones, the Englishman who plied his fast-bowling wares on the county circuit for 20 years and played three years of professional rugby too. An unforgiving one-week crash course ahead of the tournament helped Nitish add a staggering 10 kilometres per hour to his



Tight-rope walk with a coveted resource

The soft-spoken young man with a ready smile is currently back in business again, and hopefully this time, it won't be just another cameo appearance

SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

Nitish's inconsistencies, especially with the ball, can be easily explained away simply because he is still reasonably inexperienced, with less than 1,000 overs under his belt in representative cricket. Internationally, he has bowled a little over 125 overs (for 16 wickets)

bowling as he went from late 120s to 140 occasionally, but whether that has come at a cost remains to be seen.

Nitish's career, still in its infancy, is already a tale of what might be. Every performance of promise has been followed by a trough, either through loss of form or because of the unwelcome injury malady. When he made a spectacular breakthrough hundred in the Boxing Day Test at the MCG in December 2024, Nitish seemed to have made himself undroppable, but for various reasons, he has only played six subsequent Tests. Among them was the third of five Tests against England at Lord's last year, when he picked up two quick wickets to stymie a blazing start by the hosts, but he was forced to miss the rest of the series with a knee injury.

The soft-spoken young man with a ready smile is currently back in business again, and hopefully this time, it won't be another cameo appearance. As if to reiterate the value he brings to the side, Nitish walked away with the Player of the Match award in the second T20I against Afghanistan on Tuesday for his three for

24 from three good overs. A wicket with the first delivery of each of his three overs did the trick as the Afghans failed to touch 160 for the second time in three nights, allowing India to breeze home on the back of the pyrotechnics of openers Sanju Samson and Abhishek Sharma. Abhishek was the Player of the Match in the big win in the series-opener, showing that India boast match-winners aplenty at both ends of the spectrum.

Scope for improvement

Nitish's inconsistencies, especially with the ball, can be easily explained away simply because he is still reasonably inexperienced, with less than 1,000 overs under his belt in representative cricket. Internationally, he has bowled a little over 125 overs (for 16 wickets) and it might appear a stretch to label him an all-rounder immediately, but while he may not be able to influence - yet - the course of a match with his bowling alone, one can state with confidence that he will be a force to reckon with with the ball too once he manages to keep himself free from injuries.

Nitish's immediate aim will be to steer clear of injuries for at least the next two and a half months, build up a decent volume of bowling work - at the very minimum - and remain in the fray for selection for the two Test matches in New Zealand in November. There are a host of white-ball internationals between now and November 19, when the first Test gets underway at Wellington's Basin Reserve, for Nitish to achieve that goal, starting with Thursday's final T20I in New Delhi. He has been withdrawn from the Asian

Games where India will kick off their gold medal defence in the quarterfinals on September 28. Instead, he will figure in three ODIs followed by five T20Is at home against West Indies, and as many such contests in New Zealand that will segue into five further ODIs before the Test series begins.

At No. 8, where he will most likely slot in should he be available, Nitish will offer the balance India so desperately crave away from the subcontinent. It was from that position that he uncorked a fabulous hundred against the Aussies, which means there is batting depth as well as an additional pace bowling choice which is so essential on what are certain to be seaming surfaces in New Zealand. Nitish's presence will allow Shubman Gill to go into with three frontline quicks and still have five proper bowling options - Ravindra Jadeja should provide variety and experience with his left-arm spin - which is such an essential requirement in the quest for 20 wickets that could translate into victory and 12 World Test Championship points.

The recent prolificacy of the Indian top order hasn't allowed Nitish to have a bat internationally since January, and maybe there is a case for him to be pushed up the order from time to time so that he has competitive game-time in that discipline as well. As those who have played the game at any level - and even those who haven't - have pointed out repeatedly, there is no substitute for time in the middle. No number of balls hit at nets will replicate the intensity of a match scenario and India wouldn't want Nitish to go in cold from a batting standpoint when the Test matches come around with so much hinging on the outcome. That's where Gill and head coach Gautam Gambhir will have to walk the tricky tightrope of balancing the immediate (results) with the immediate future (match readiness).

India have been forced to approach several fixtures in the recent past with the full complement never available for selection. Some of the 'offenders' in the injury list fall in the 'serial' category - Jasprit Bumrah, Pandya (who hasn't represented the country since March), Harshit Rana, Washington Sundar and Nitish.

Despite the depth that speaks to the vibrancy of Indian cricket, this is far from an ideal scenario. Gill, the Test and ODI boss, and T20I captain Shreyas Iyer, will be desperate for the luxury of picking from the complete riches. Nitish might not be on top of the 'riches' section, but he is a much-coveted resource whose progress over the next 75 days will be followed with interest. And optimism.

THE GIST

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